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~ Elías Flores

Elías Flores (@zeeliasfineart) is a visual artist and painter from Peru. Passionate about figurative expression and the study of light, Elías has developed a body of work where contrast and texture take center stage. Through his work and deep dedication to charcoal drawing, he explores themes such as portraiture, classical realism, and nature. His creative process is rooted in tradition and the quality of materials, utilizing chiaroscuro to give life and atmosphere to every piece. Currently, he shares his process and artwork with an international community through his platform **zeeliasfineart.com**, establishing himself as an emerging talent from Southern Peru to the world.

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Artists & ILLUSTRATORS

From the editor

At last! The nights are longer, the sky brighter and the sun is making a welcome appearance. So, you know what this calls for? *En plein air* painting. In what will be her second cover for *Artists & Illustrators* whilst yours truly has been at the helm, Haidee-Jo Summers tells us why she likes to paint *alla prima*, on location, and in three hours or less. She says her work is, "a celebration of light-filled moments," which is something the In the Studio artist, Alice Boggis-Rolfe, can relate to with her landscapes captured on travels abroad. Did someone say the word holiday?

In practical news, the April cover star, Janet Mayled shows you how she captures one of her charming allotment scenes, Naomi Jenkin paints a soothing seascape, British Art Prize finalist Rodney Kingston depicts a scene outside a football stadium (proof that you can paint whatever your passion may be) whilst we've got a sun imbued still life from Tom Shepherd.

With more pages than ever before, we continue with our brand-new section, The Art Index, which caters to those eager to learn and expand on their art practice. Offering more value and inspiration, it's your go-to for UK art club listings, workshop news, product reviews plus advice and tips from the experts.

Then, we introduce you to our stellar line up of judges for this year's British Art Prize. With a diverse wealth of experience, all entrants will get their work seen by this talented bunch. Not only that, but there are also cash prizes up for grabs, premium art products to be won, two central London gallery opportunities and valuable coverage in *Artists & Illustrators*, Britain's best-loved art magazine. The floor is yours.

Niki Browes Editor

ON THE COVER

The Geese at Cadgwith Cove
Haidee-Jo Summers

Contact us!

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INTRODUCING

HAIDEE-JO SUMMERS

Haidee-Jo is a full-time professional artist known for painting gardens, landscapes and seascapes *en plein air*. Vice President of the Royal Institute of Oil painters (VPROI) and an elected member of the Royal Society of Marine Artists (RSMA) her work can be seen each year at the Mall Galleries in London. She is also the author of three books on painting with oil.

RODNEY KINGSTON

Rodney is a professional oil painter who captures everyday subjects through portraiture, still life and landscapes. Working from life is the driving force behind his work which has led him to travel up and down the country painting football fans outside stadiums on match days. He loves to share his knowledge of painting through demonstrations and workshops.

NAOMI JENKIN

A professional artist based in Cornwall, Naomi's love for the sea has shaped both her life and her art. An avid surfer, she draws inspiration from the ocean's dynamic beauty and likes to capture the sea's in every form, from wild and stormy to calm and serene. Inspired by nature, Naomi sells original paintings and limited editions of her work.

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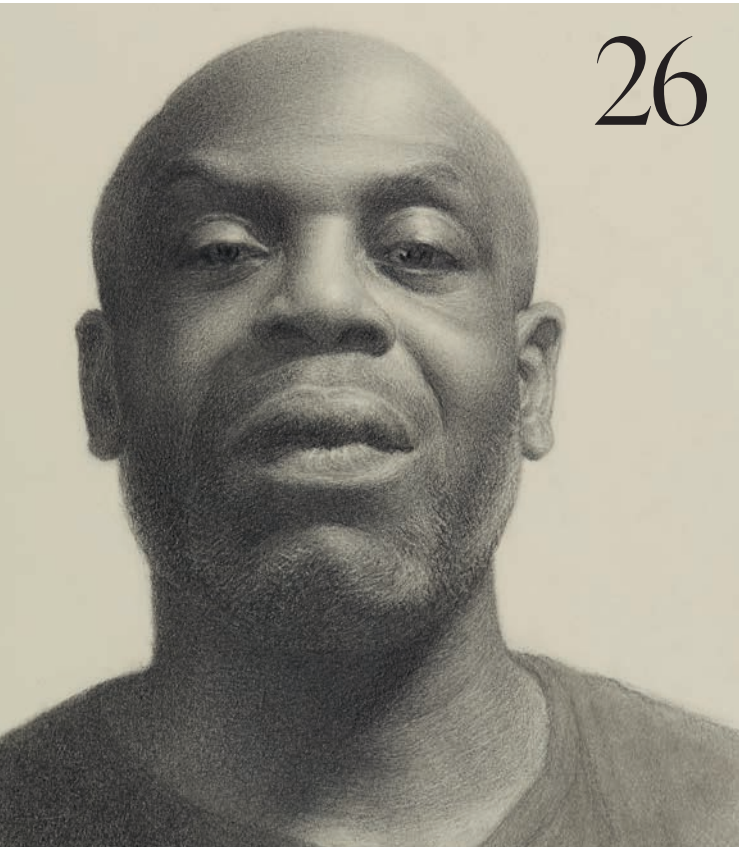
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Amanda Beck	Brigitte Girling	Hannah Farthing

Painting Holidays 2026

Arctic	Polar Bears and Glaciers	03 - 12 Jun
UK	Orkney: Seabirds and Clifftops	07 - 13 Jun
Spain	Picasso Country	08 - 15 Jun
Austria	Viennese Whirl	16 - 21 Jun
South Africa	Kruger: Where The Wild Dogs Run	18 - 26 Aug
UK	Secret Suffolk Nature	01 - 05 Sep
UK	Norfolk: Windmill in the Reeds	14 - 18 Sep
Zambia	Large, Grey and Unmistakable	01 - 08 Oct
Bhutan	Land of the Thunder Dragon	12 - 23 Nov
Galapagos	Darwin's Islands	05 - 18 Dec

Painting Holidays 2027

Oman	Arabian Days and Nights	Jan
Sri Lanka	Sun, Sapphire and Spice	Feb
Mexico	Colour Wheel of Oaxaca	Feb
Japan	Floating Landscapes	Apr
Uzbekistan	Splendours of the Silk Route	Apr
UK	Cornwall: Boconnoc in Bloom	Apr
Bulgaria	The Spring Colours of Bulgaria	May
Slovenia	Alpine Meadows & Wildlife	May
Spain	Picasso Country	Jun
Georgia	Wine, Silk and Song	Jun
Zambia	Where Leopards Tread	Jun
Albania	Secrets of Albania	Jul
Mongolia	Nomadic Mongolia	Jul
Malawi	Warm Heart of Africa	Sep
Zambia	Large, Grey and Unmistakable	Oct
Tanzania	Safari and Spice Island in Zanzibar	Oct
India	Wildlife of India	Nov
Antarctica	In Shackleton's Footsteps	Dec

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ART SAFARI

Sketchbook

TIPS • ADVICE • EXHIBITIONS • NEWS • REVIEWS

EDITED BY RAMSHA VISTRO

COURTESY OF THE ARTIST AND CBPP

Winconek Oliver, *The Tailor*, oil on panel

Editor's pick...

Contemporary British Portrait Painters returns to Brixton this June with a sharp, wide-ranging look at portraiture today. Featuring over 50 artists, including past winners of the National Portrait Gallery Prize and Sky Arts Portrait Artist of the Year, the exhibition reflects how contemporary painters are reworking likeness across style and scale. Founded in 2018, the artist-led collective prioritises quality-led selection and collaboration. All works are for sale, with proceeds going directly to artists. Free admission. *From 6 to 14 June. Downstairs at The Department Store, Brixton, London SW9 8FR.* ***thecbpp.org*** □

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Don't miss...

Two new cinema releases this May that turn the spotlight on art-world icons, exploring how image, biography and myth are constructed over time. Frida Kahlo returns to UK cinemas on 19 May in an extended encore edition ahead of the Tate Modern and MFA Houston exhibition *Frida: The Making of an Icon*. The film revisits Kahlo's life through letters, expert commentary and new material, tracing her transformation from painter to global cultural symbol and the rise of "Fridamania." A week later, *Moss & Freud* (from 29 May) examines the charged dynamic between Kate Moss and Lucian Freud, reconstructing the long portrait sittings where discipline, tension and intimacy blur, and a commission evolves into an uneasy exchange of control and influence. ***vertigoreleasing.com, exhibitiononscreen.com***

Explore...

A solo exhibition of work by Ken Price that brings together sculpture and drawing by the American artist, whose practice redefined the possibilities of ceramics. The show includes works from the 1960s onwards, highlighting his use of layered pigment, organic form and highly finished surfaces. Drawings are presented alongside the sculptures, revealing development of ideas across media and his sustained engagement with form and material. *Until 25 July 2026 at Lisson Gallery, London NW1 5BY.* ***lissongallery.com***

PRICE UNREALISTIC RECLUSE 2005

PRICE CEEJAY 2011

LYNN CHADWICK, BEAST ALERTED I, 1990, STAINLESS STEEL. COURTESY OF HE ARTIST'S ESTATE/PANGOLIN LONDON. PHOTO: STEVE RUSSELL STUDIOS

SCULPTING MODERN BRITAIN

A major exhibition brings together the largest presentation of Lynn Chadwick's sculpture in over two decades, spanning more than 30 works from the 1950s through to the 1990s. Early mobiles, paired "couples" and the artist's iconic "beasts" are shown alongside rarely seen late stainless-steel works, charting a career defined by construction, tension and material innovation. Trained as an architectural draughtsman, Chadwick developed a distinctive sculptural language built from welded armatures and layered surfaces. The show also revisits his international breakthrough at the Venice Biennale and his lasting influence on post-war British sculpture. *Until 4 October 2026 at Houghton Hall, Norfolk, PE31 6UE.* ***houghtonhall.com***

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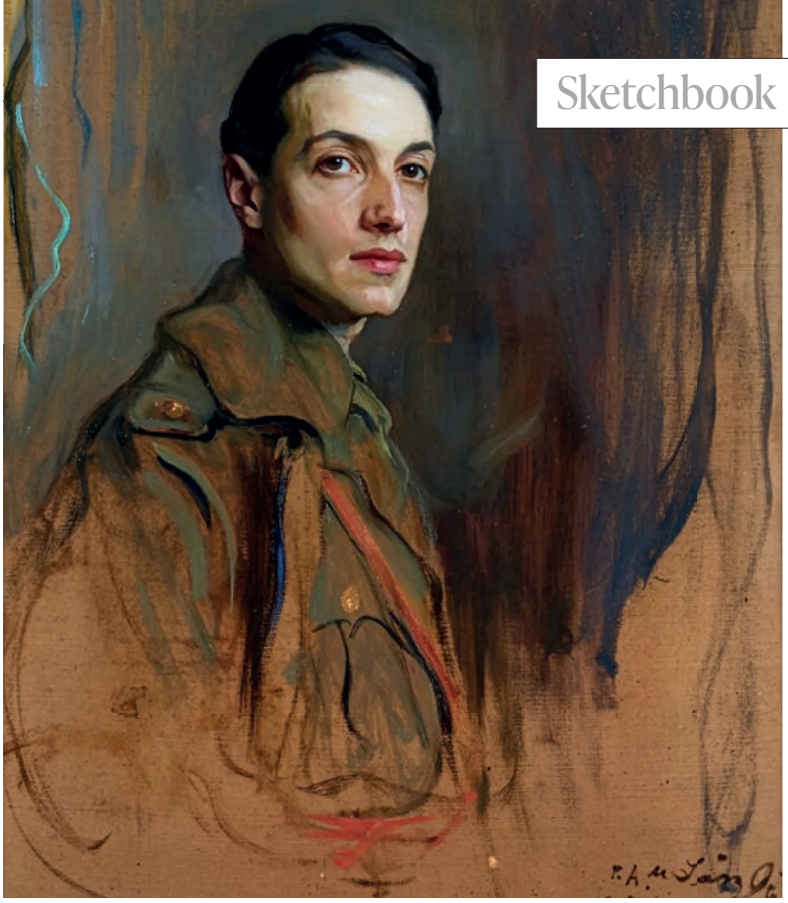


PHILIP DE LÁSZLÓ, PORTRAIT OF PHILIP SASSOON, 1915

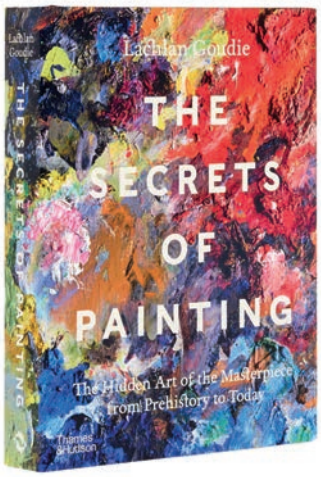
HOUSE OF SECRETS

One of London's most colourful historic houses, Trent Park House, will open to the public as a museum for the first time this summer, revealing its role as a secret intelligence centre during the Second World War. Senior German officers were held at the house, unaware their conversations were being recorded by hidden listening devices, providing vital intelligence to the Allies. Restored state rooms reflect its earlier life as the residence of Sir Philip Sassoon, while basement spaces recreate the work of the "Secret Listeners," bringing together the house's interwar and wartime histories. *Trent Park House, Enfield, London EN4.* ***trentparkhouse.org.uk***

12 PORTRAIT WALL AND PAN-EUROPEAN STORY

THE ROTHSCHILD STORY RETOLD

A new display at Waddesdon Manor revisits the Rothschild story, tracing the family's journey from the Jewish ghetto of 18th-century Frankfurt to the rise of their international banking empire and the creation of landmark houses and collections, with Waddesdon as its most complete surviving expression. Reconsidered by curators and redesigned by ZMMA, the rooms incorporate digital and interactive elements to update displays first installed after the 1996 Centenary Restoration. The narrative highlights key figures from Baron Ferdinand to Lord Rothschild and Dame Hannah, while placing new emphasis on female influence, collecting, and the family's enduring engagement with nature, horticulture and sustainability. *Until 1 November 2026. Waddesdon Manor, Buckinghamshire HP18 0JH.* ***waddesdon.org.uk***



BOOK OF THE MONTH

THE SECRETS OF PAINTING BY LACHLAN GOUDIE

This book reframes art history through process rather than theory. Moving from prehistoric cave pigments to digital media, artist, writer and broadcaster Goudie tracks the materials and techniques that shape each era. Grounded in studio experience, he reveals painting as a physical, often difficult act; where innovation emerges through trial, resistance and the artist's relationship with their tools. ***Thames & Hudson, £38.00***

Join us online!

These pages are packed with artistic inspiration, but if you're after more, explore the fabulous *Artists & Illustrators* website. A go-to resource for artists across all disciplines, it offers a wealth of practical guides, exciting competitions and engaging interviews. Discover even more creative resources and inspiration. See you there. ***artistsandillustrators.co.uk***

THE DIARY

Open calls, prizes and artist opportunities

27 MAY
Respond to themes of nature and conservation for the Pensychnant Open 2026, with selected works exhibited in North Wales. £15 entry. ***pensychnant.co.uk***

2 JUNE
UK-based artists can enter The Hogarth Prize for a chance to win £3,000, exhibit at Hogarth's House and secure a solo show. Entry from £16. ***hogarthshouse.org***

3 JUNE
Submissions are open for the Green & Stone Summer Exhibition 2026, offering the opportunity to show in a leading gallery. £20. ***thegalleryatgreenandstone.com***

9 JUNE
The Trinity Buoy Wharf Drawing Prize 2026 welcomes entries with major awards and a national touring exhibition available; £30 entry fee. ***trinitybuoywharf.com***

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Exhibitions

THE BEST ART SHOWS TO VISIT FROM THIS MONTH ONWARDS

ANDY WARHOL (1928-1987) CAMPBELL'S SOUP (1968) COURTESY WOLVERHAMPTON ART GALLERY © THE ANDY WARHOL FOUNDATION FOR THE VISUAL ARTS, INC. / DACS, LONDON, 2026. TRADEMARKS LICENSED BY CAMPBELL SOUP COMPANY. ALL RIGHTS RESERVED

ANDY WARHOL: ART STAR

23 May to 4 October 2026

A major exhibition at Wolverhampton Art Gallery presents works by Andy Warhol, one of the defining figures of post-war Pop Art. Drawn from the ARTIST ROOMS collection in partnership with Tate and National Galleries of Scotland, the exhibition brings together drawings, screenprints, paintings and photographs from the 1950s to the 1980s. Iconic images of Marilyn Monroe, The Beatles and Elizabeth Taylor appear alongside works centred on consumer culture, including Campbell's Soup. Early commercial illustrations, lesser-known photographic works and late-career experiments are also included, tracing Warhol's evolving visual language across four decades.
Wolverhampton Art Gallery, Lichfield Street, Wolverhampton WV1 1DU. wolverhamptonart.org.uk

SIMEON STAFFORD SUMMER HOLIDAYS, DAYMER BAY, OIL ON CANVAS

SIMEON STAFFORD: 70TH BIRTHDAY SOLO EXHIBITION

30 June to 28 July 2026

A major solo exhibition marks Simeon Stafford's 70th birthday, bringing together new work rooted in his life in Cornwall and wider British scenes. Stafford's recognisable cast of characters reappear across the works, adding energy to his distinctive, figurative style developed over a career spanning four decades. ***Whitewater Contemporary, Polzeath, PL27 6SR. whitewatercontemporary.co.uk***

CATHIE PILKINGTON: ON THE TABLE (DETAIL), 2023. FABRIC, PLASTER, STRAW, RESIN, CAR FILLER, PAINT, MASKING TAPE, RUBBER, LINOLEUM, PAPER, GLITTER CURTAIN AND WOOD, 165X305X100 CM. PHOTOGRAPH: PEROU. COURTESY OF THE ARTIST

RESPONSE TO A REQUEST (OR SPASM OF THE SOUL)

Until 14 June 2026

Bringing together a wide range of artists, this group exhibition is curated by Brian Griffiths. Framed by Robert Walser's 1907 short story *Response to a Request*, it examines the gap between instruction and outcome, where meaning is shaped as much by interruption as by intention. The works resist fixed interpretation, shifting between excess, ambiguity and partial resolution.
Elizabeth Xi Bauer, London EC1R 4QE. elizabethxibauer.com

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PAUL BROWN: OIL PAINTINGS MMXXVI

18 to 24 May 2026

A solo exhibition of new oil paintings by Paul Brown features views of London, Venice and coastal scenes. The works reflect over four decades of practice and explore shifting light and atmosphere across recognisable landscapes.

340 Kings Road, Chelsea, London SW3 5UR. sanguine-fine-art.co.uk

JACK WHITE AND DAMIEN HIRST, PHOTOGRAPHED BY DAVID JAMES SWANSON © THE ARTIST

JACK WHITE: THESE THOUGHTS MAY DISAPPEAR

29 May to 13 September 2026

Artist and *White Stripes* star Jack White presents his first major UK exhibition at Newport Street Gallery, unveiling a multidisciplinary visual practice that spans sculpture, furniture design and found-object assemblage. Featuring interactive works, installations and a recreation of his 2015 sculpture *The Red Tree*, the show reflects his "hardware store art" approach, shaped by Detroit's Cass Corridor and mid-century design. Arranged in association with HENI, the exhibition marks White's first public presentation of his visual work.

Newport Street Gallery, London SE11 6AJ. newportstreetgallery.com

GODFRIED DONKOR, PARTS BEYOND THE SEAS, 2025. EMBROIDERY ON DIGITALLY COLLAGED FT PAPER, 254.5X224CM. COURTESY OF THE ARTIST AND GALLERY 1957

GODFRIED DONKOR: IT'S A NUMBERS GAME

23 May to 30 August 2026

This exhibition brings together new and existing work from Godfried Donker spanning collage, painting, embroidery and installation. The show explores histories of empire, commerce and identity, where archival imagery, financial newspaper pages, and Ghanaian Adinkra motifs are brought into direct dialogue. The works examine how historical narratives are constructed, repeated and reinterpreted.

Firstsite, Lewis Gardens, High Street, Colchester CO1 1JH. firstsite.uk

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This month, we've teamed up with STAEDTLER to offer four readers the chance to win an Artist Series bundle worth over £250 each. STAEDTLER's Artist Series focuses on the practical side of drawing, bringing together materials that support both early sketching and more developed work. At the centre is the Mars Lumograph range, known for its consistency and range of tones, making it a reliable choice for everything from light line work to deeper shading.

This bundle moves across different approaches, combining graphite, aquarell and charcoal pencils to allow for variation in texture and finish. Whether working with dry materials or introducing water for softer effects, the tools offer a straightforward way to explore and refine technique.

A selection of essential accessories is also included, covering blending, sharpening and erasing. These are designed to make adjustments easier and help maintain a steady workflow, rather than interrupting it.

Taken together, the set offers a well-rounded introduction to the Artist Series, while still being useful for those looking to expand their existing materials. It's a practical collection that supports a range of styles without overcomplicating the process. Now's your chance to try STAEDTLER's Artist Series for yourself.

staedtler.com

THE PRIZE

Four winners, chosen at random, will each receive one bundle worth over £250, including:

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- **Mars Lumograph Black Pencil set in 6 assorted degrees. *£11.95***
- **Mars Lumograph Charcoal Pencil set of 3 assorted degrees. *£6.96***
- **Mars Lumograph Pure Graphite Pencil set in 6 assorted degrees. *£16.95***
- **Mars Lumograph Jumbo Pencil in 5 assorted degrees. *£13.75***
- **Mars Lumograph Colour Aquarell Pencil set in 60 assorted colours. *£112.95***
- **Double-hole tub sharpener for graphite and colour pencils. *£5.42***
- **Kneadable art eraser. *£2.01***
- **Mars plastic eraser. *£1.88***
- **Blender Pencil. *£3.16***
- **Water Brush set in 4 sizes. *£20.29***

HOW TO ENTER

Submit your entry by 23.59 on 1 July 2026 at: **artistsandillustrators.co.uk/competitions**

TERMS & CONDITIONS Four winners only. The prize is non-transferable and no cash alternative is available. For full terms and conditions, visit artistsandillustrators.co.uk

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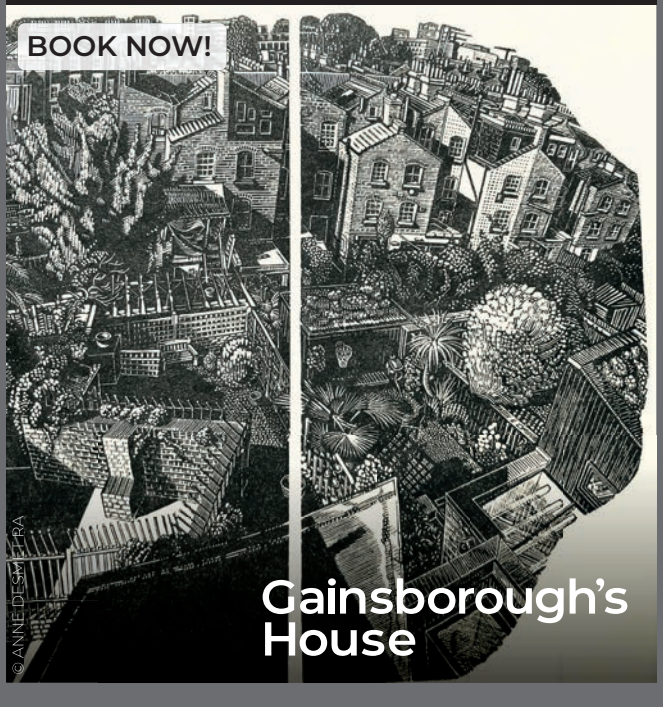

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This month's spotlight on a British Art Club member

We present...

SARAH WILD

Coastal scenes and seascapes inspire this artist, especially if they have huge, dramatic skies

Having visited North Norfolk for years, Sarah Wild bought a little holiday cottage there and was looking forward to spending time painting the open spaces and dramatic skies, when COVID hit. "Being stuck in Sheffield for months and unable to visit, one thing I could do was dig out my huge library of photos of the Norfolk coast and spend time creating lots of artwork for the cottage, ready for when we could visit again," she remembers. "Then, in 2021 I took a career break which enabled me to focus fully on painting for a while and build up a body of work and that really got my landscape painting off the ground."

Her work often captures the huge skies and changing light of the coast and, even though she doesn't paint *en plein air*, Sarah walks regularly to gain inspiration. "I have hundreds of photos of some of my favourite places," she says. "I spend a lot of time going through these images to select the ones I think will work as a painting. I then sketch them out loosely and go in quickly with paint – mainly acrylics and occasionally watercolours."

It's the sky that makes a scene appealing to Sarah. "Particularly the clouds," she says. "The sky is always a key focus of my paintings, whether bright and sunny or dark and stormy. Sometimes I spend a lot of time working on the colour and clouds and light, but other times the sky comes together quite quickly."

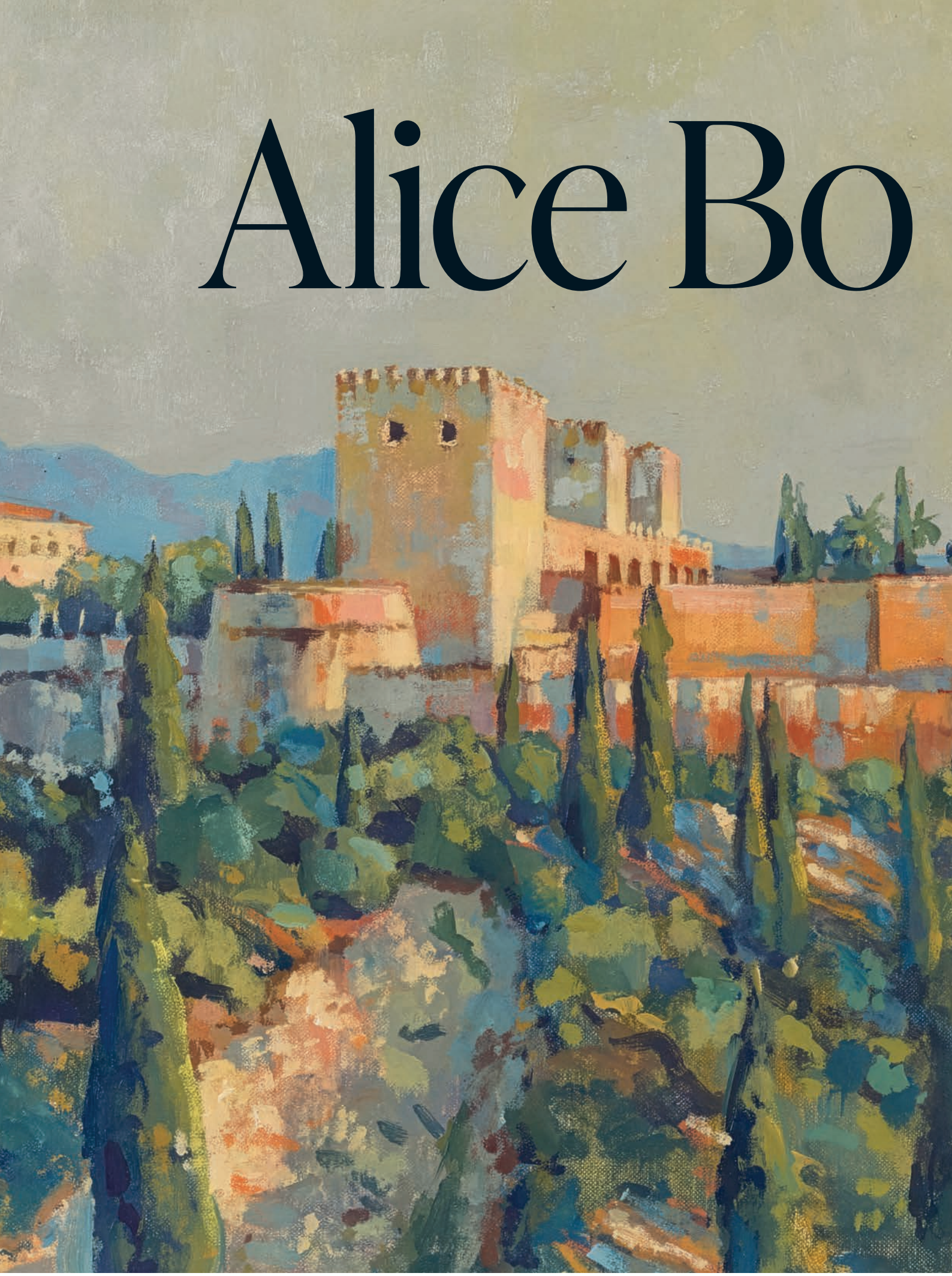
One of the biggest challenges Sarah faces as an artist is finding time to paint. "It's a struggle, juggling a job and other responsibilities before I can squeeze in any time for creating – I sometimes don't manage it for long periods," she admits. "I try to make use of small chunks of time to plan and prepare my ideas, so that when I have a few hours to actually paint, I can get straight on with it."

Being a member of The British Art Club has helped her create an online presence. "It's a great way to build an online portfolio without having to manage a website," she says. "I also use my Instagram account to showcase work among posts about our holiday cottage – where a lot of my work is displayed – and the beautiful scenery there. They are all connected and it reaches a wider audience than just showing my work."

britishartclub.co.uk/profile/sarahwild □

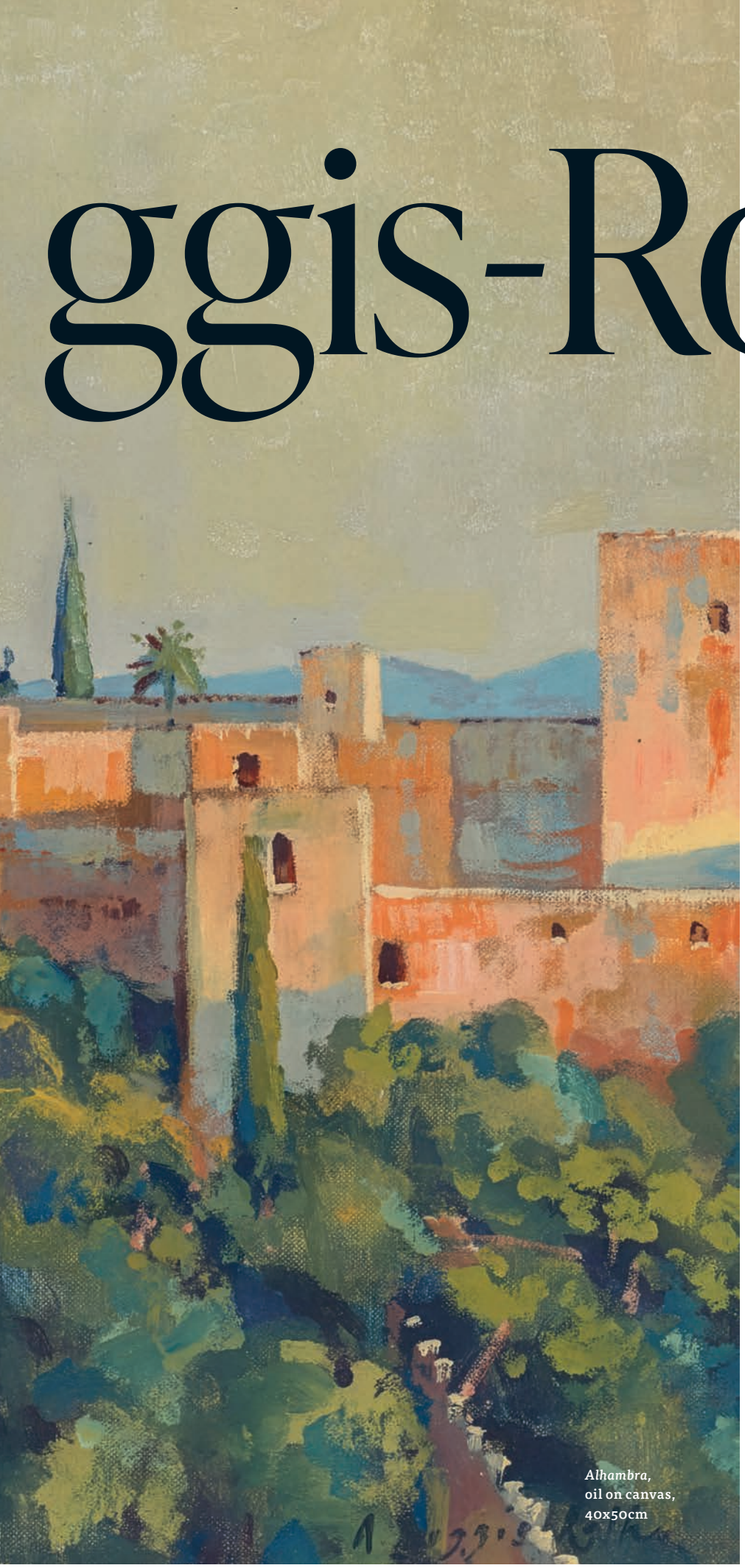
Burnham Overy Sky, acrylic, 30x40cm

Alice Bo



ggis-Rolfe

This oil artist's work ranges from vast, open landscapes to portraits and intimate interiors. *Sarah Edghill* hears what inspires her creativity



Alhambra, oil on canvas, 40x50cm

Alice Boggis-Rolfe has always travelled extensively with her art, but when back home in Gloucestershire, she revels in being able to spend time in what her husband describes as her "absolutely revolting" studio. Alice is undeterred by such criticism and enjoys the unruliness of her surroundings, while admitting that her parents used to despair when, as a child, she left trails of paint, paper and pencil shavings all over the house.

"When I'm stuck into a project I don't notice the chaos," she says. "Old paint tubes, scraps of canvas, books, old brushes, coffee cups, all building up around me. Last year, we moved and now I have a new studio at the top of the house near my children's bedrooms. It's a haven of calm and a retreat for me from busy family life. I have a comfy old leather armchair, a dog bed for my beloved terrier, several big easels with paintings on the go, an overflowing desk under a window, hundreds of reference books of artists and art history, chests and shelves full of materials, new brushes, tubes of paint and pin boards with all sorts of things that make me happy or inspired. Since it's up in the attic, there are skylights on both sides and I also have some lighting equipment for still lifes." ▶

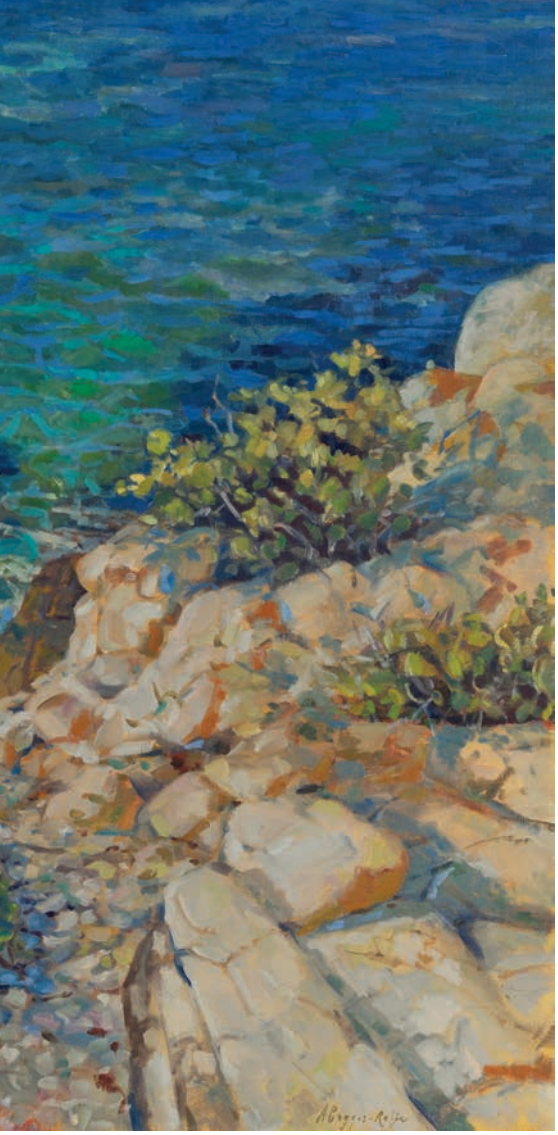
Alice did a foundation course at Chelsea, followed by a Portraiture Diploma at Heatherley's School of Fine Art. "We had different teachers every few weeks, all of them practising artists. At the time it could be confusing as they all had their own approaches, but looking back it was really helpful to learn in that way. It allowed me to find my own language and style of working rather than be fed a formula. We did life drawing every week, and this is something I carried on doing for years after I left. It's an important discipline no matter what you want to paint."

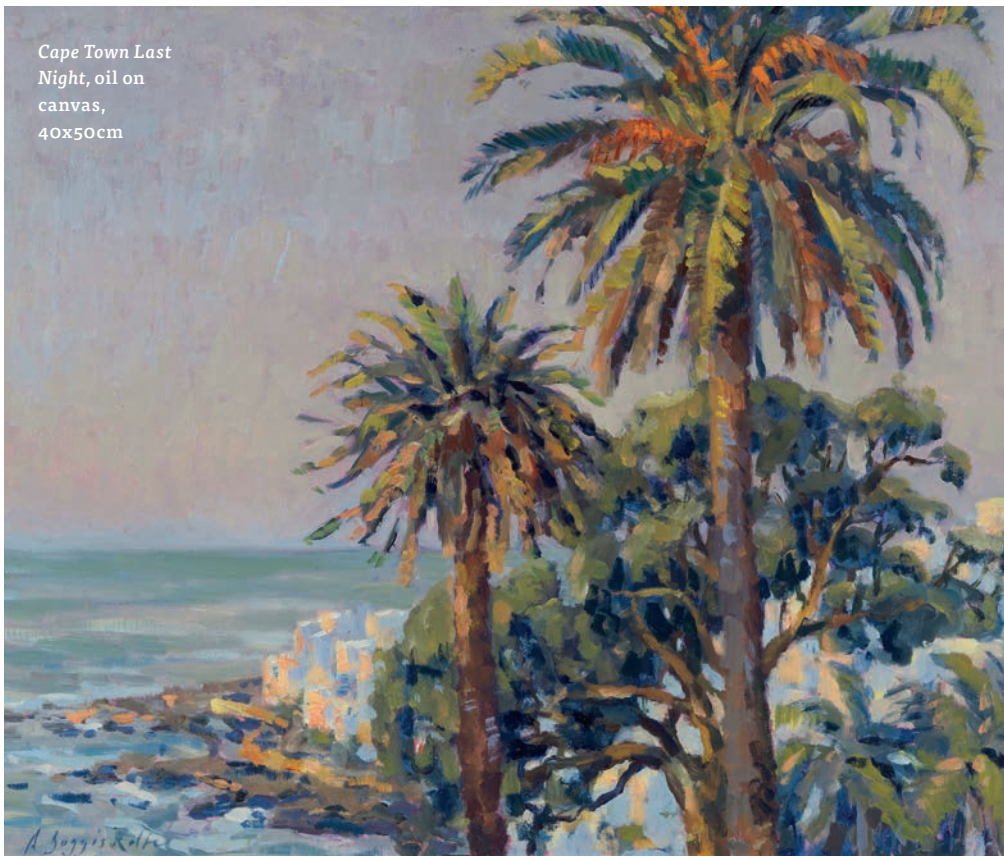
Having had her first commission at the age of 15, Alice was already working on portraits and pet portraits while at art school, and had her first solo exhibition when she was just 25. "I was so nervous I had panic attacks in the lead up," she admits. "But to my astonishment it was quite successful and drove me on to the next one."

Throughout her twenties, she travelled the world with her paints, holding exhibitions back in London between trips. "That was a special time," she says. "I now have a family and young children, which is also special but very different.

Shoals,
oil on canvas,
90x120cm

Magnolia,
oil on canvas,
30x40cm





Cape Town Last Night, oil on canvas, 40x50cm

Prayer Flags and Rickshaws in Kathmandu, oil on canvas, 30x25cm

When she does get the opportunity to get away painting, it's even more exhilarating. " I am currently the artist in residence at an archaeological dig in Egypt where they have discovered the tomb of Pharaoh Thutmose II. So, I have been going out there sporadically for a week at a time and painting from 5am until sunset every day. It's a magical place and I know it feeds into my work when I am totally immersed like that."

Alice mostly uses oil, but has also recently started working with gouache. "It can produce similar work but is quicker and takes up less space in my suitcase so I can work on family holidays," she says. Her landscapes and still lifes both bear her characteristic style, but are also very different, and she clearly finds it easy to switch between subjects. "It depends on what I see or what inspires me on any given day. I get bored doing the same thing over and over again. If the morning sun creeps over a beautiful plant on my kitchen windowsill I can't resist painting it. And if I have just arrived in a foreign city and can hear the buzz outside, I can't wait to get out in it with my brushes. So long as something catches my attention and I ▶

Palms in Hermanus, gouache on paper, 21x15cm

Iris Stem, oil on panel, 30x40cm

Tree of Life, oil on panel, 25x30cm

am inspired by painting it, I have no preference as to what it is."

Combining an artistic career with the demands of a young family isn't always easy, and Alice admits her working process isn't predictable. "Sometimes a painting can be done in the heat of the moment and has a freshness that could easily be spoiled," she explains. "But more often than not I return to paintings a few times. I do work quickly. If I go on a painting trip for a week, I'll come back with around 30 unfinished paintings, and when I get home, I put them all away for a few weeks. Then, when I'm ready, I'll return to them in my studio. Some are finished as they are, some I rework, some are seedlings for larger pictures and – most importantly – some go in the bin."

She is an artist who prefers to paint in silence, as she finds music or podcasts distracting. "However, we live in a secluded valley surrounded by woods, so I listen to the birds all day – and my dog snoring." As someone who has always painted *en plein air*, she knows it isn't possible to stay undisturbed while at work. "Sometimes it's great to interact with people," she says. "I remember having hilarious conversations with the locals in Cuba using my terrible attempt at Spanish, as they posed for me or told me about the history of the place. But some people can be very intrusive which is hard to deal with. Selfie sticks are the worst – argh!"

Alongside her painting trips, she holds regular solo exhibitions. "I paint manically for eight months to a year and then have to stop painting to direct all my energy into putting the exhibition together, which takes a few months. For the last few, I have made all the frames too, which was fun but very time consuming. It's amazing how different the feel of a finished painting can be, depending on what frame you put it in, and I love experimenting with all the materials, glazes and gilding to elevate or downplay a painting."

Alongside all this activity, there is little time for commissions and she is very choosy about those requests she does take on. "I find it almost impossible to paint something if I'm not inspired by it," she admits. "And I find the process of working with a price tag on the unfinished piece very stressful. It fills me with self-doubt and can lead to me overworking paintings."

aliceboggis-rolfe.com □

HOW I MAKE IT WORK

Johnty Robinson

This artist turned classical training into a disciplined, full-time painting career

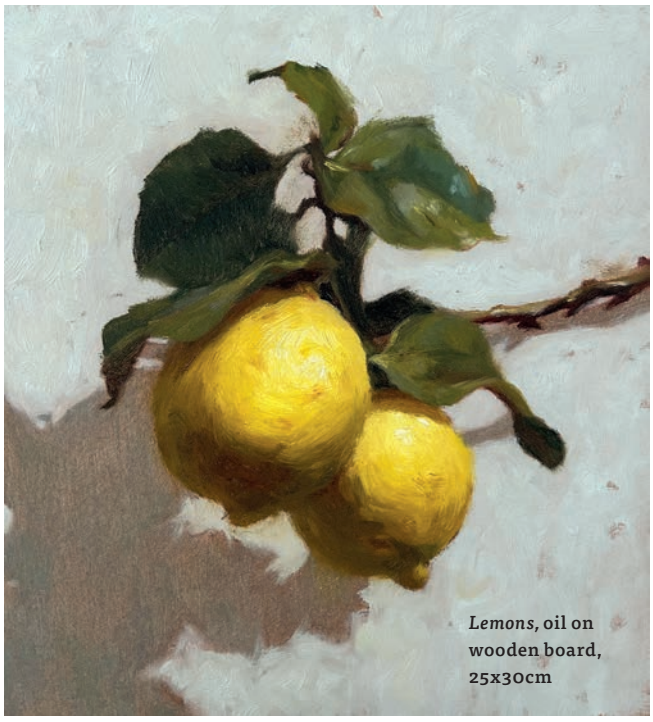
Although I'd always enjoyed art, it was an evening course at London Fine Art Studios that made me fall in love with it. Over those 10 weeks, I realised that drawing and painting could be taught, and quickly recognised it as my dream career. I continued working in my tech job until I'd saved enough to study there full-time. I trained there for 15 months, learning how to draw and paint from life. I then went on to briefly teach there before moving to Cornwall. That training completely shaped how I work today.

I think slowing down and appreciating the everyday leads to a happier life. I love that my work allows me to get excited about little things like seasonal fruit and flowers, and I love being on the lookout for new objects to include in my still lifes. This perspective seems to resonate with collectors.

Don't let rejection discourage you; it's an inevitable part of being an artist. My work has been turned down many times. The key is to use that disappointment as motivation to improve. Also, just apply to competitions. Winning the Winsor & Newton Young Artist Award at the ROI Annual Exhibition in 2025 has helped in every part of my artistic career.

Social media is annoyingly part of being an artist today. Find a way to produce content that is non-intrusive and doesn't rely on clickbait.

Bowl full of Grapes, oil on wooden board, 25x25cm



Lemons, oil on wooden board, 25x30cm

Timelapse videos have been very effective for me. It's a simple way to share my process without interrupting my work. That said, the priority should always be the quality of the art itself. You can create viral content, but if the work isn't strong, it won't hold interest.

I am an extremely unromantic painter. To paraphrase a fantastic tutor I once had, there are two types of passion in art: hot and cold. Cold passion is having a long-term goal, like wanting to be a world-class painter and sticking with it even when you are not feeling inspired. My daily routine reflects this. I start work at 9am and finish at 5pm, five days a week. It's a difficult industry financially. Treating it like a full-time job helps.

johntyrobinsonart.co.uk □

JOHNTY'S TIPS FOR BECOMING A FULL-TIME ARTIST

1

Struggling to mix a colour?
Try adding Raw Umber.

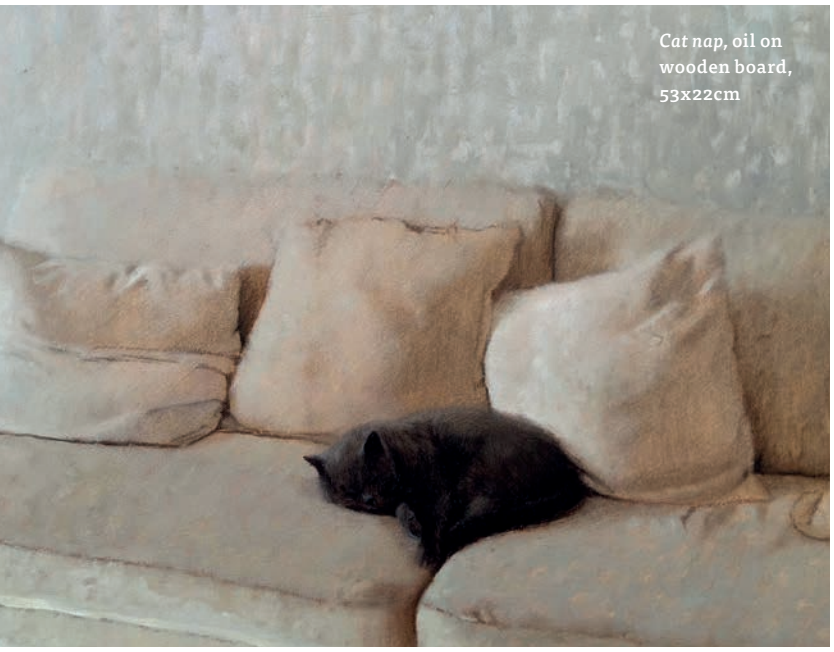
2

Don't rely on the idea of talent
Focus on consistent improvement. There is a fantastic book I recommend called *Grit* by Angela Duckworth that explains this.

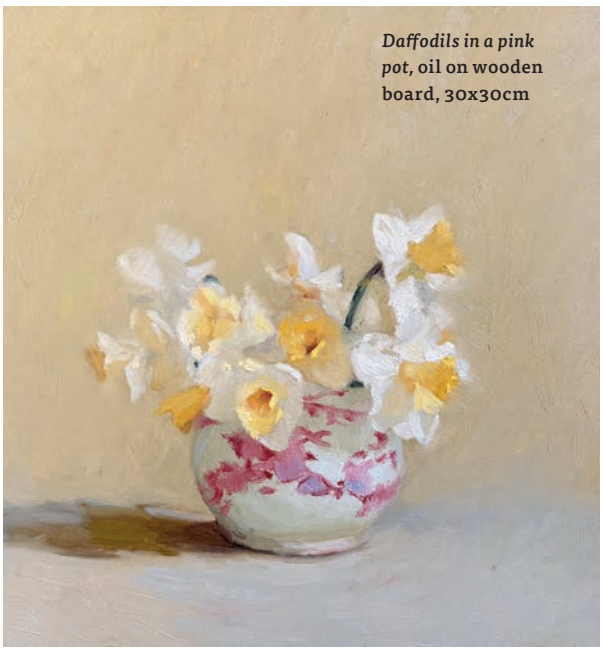
3

Relax
When I am teaching, I know a student is going to struggle if they are getting annoyed at themselves. It's only a painting; it really doesn't matter. Take a deep breath, go for a walk and come back to it with a clear mind.

Sardines on a yellow plate, oil on wooden board, 25x25cm



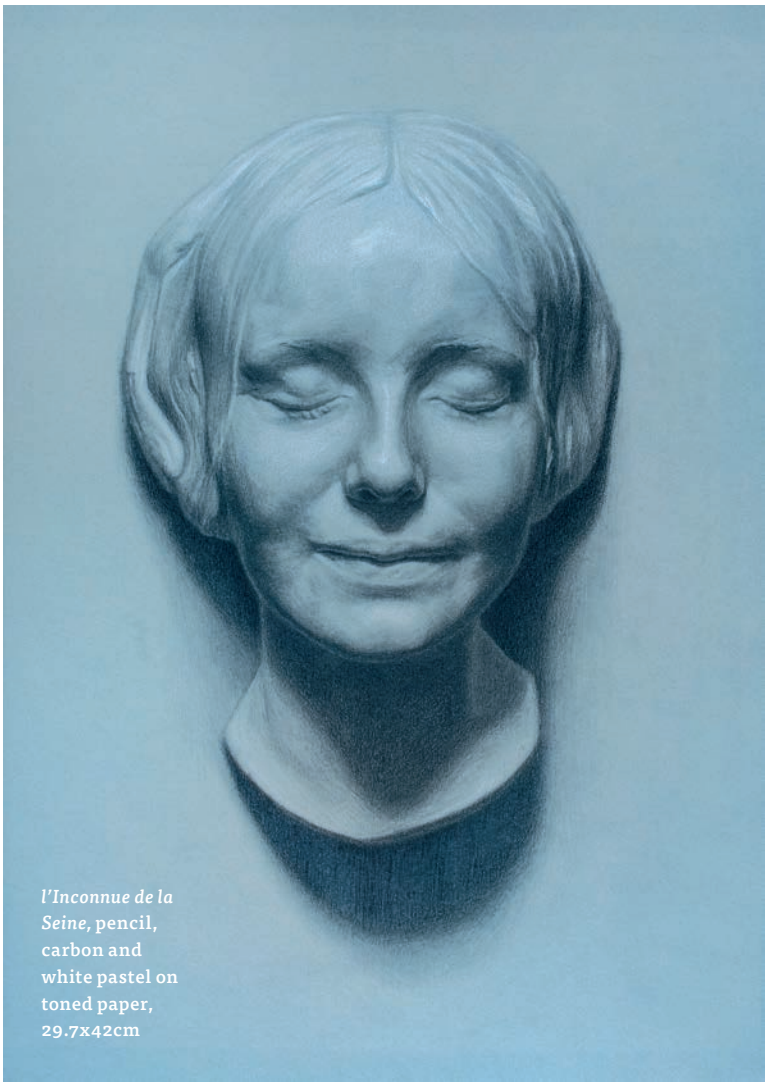
Cat nap, oil on wooden board, 53x22cm



Daffodils in a pink pot, oil on wooden board, 30x30cm

Sergej Draskovic

The winner of the 2026 Raw Umber Image Reference Prize, Serbian artist **SERGEJ DRASKOVIC**, tells *Niki Browes* how he approaches portraiture

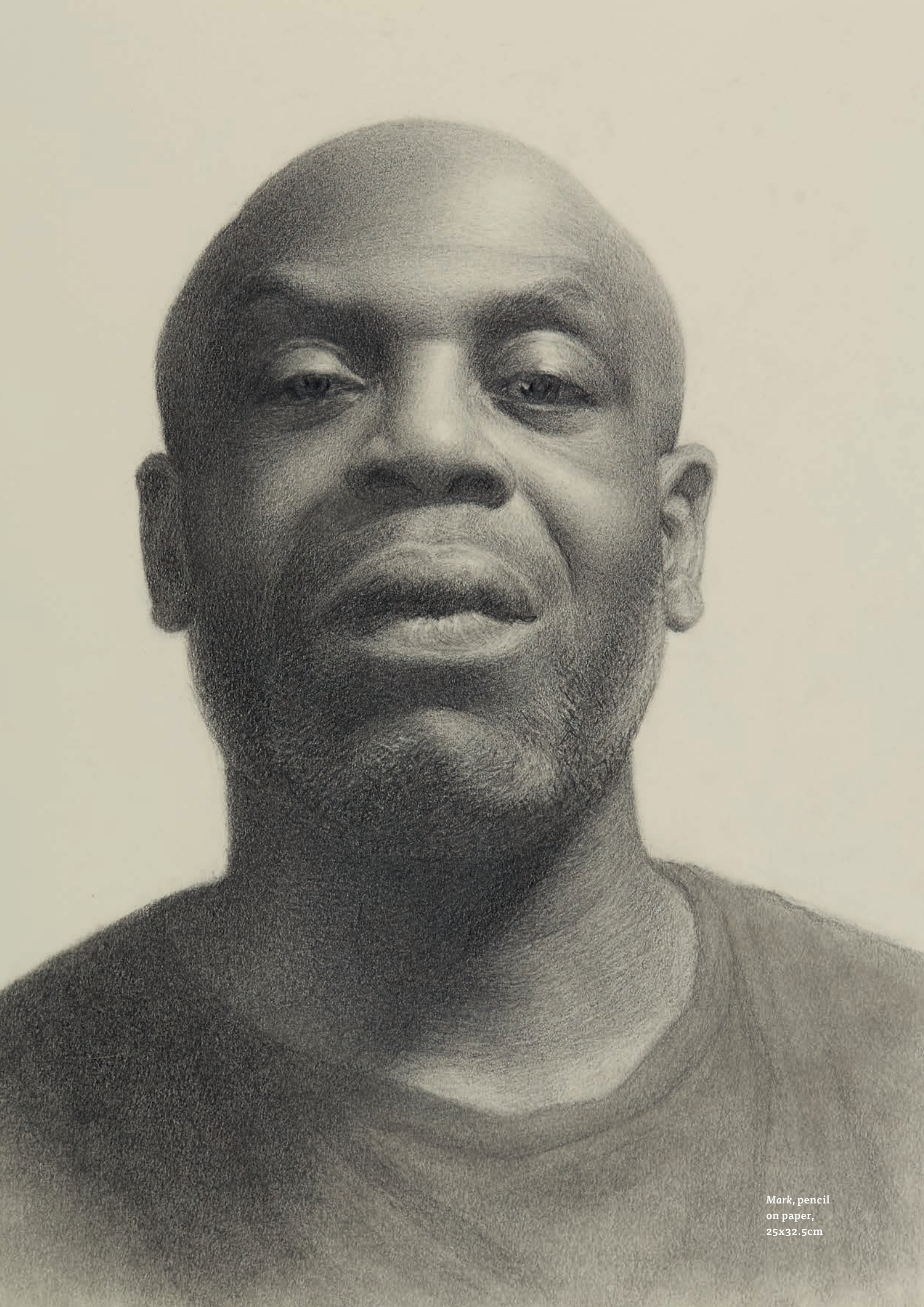


l'Inconnue de la Seine, pencil, carbon and white pastel on toned paper, 29.7x42cm

As a child, Sergej Draskovic was fascinated by wild animals and for a long time they were the only thing he drew. Through reading comics, he learnt to imitate some of the techniques used by comic artists, then started to draw faces from imagination. He studied painting at the Faculty of Fine Art in Belgrade, graduating in 2004, and in recent years he has focused almost exclusively on drawing portraits with graphite on paper. Earlier this year, he was awarded the Raw Umber Image Reference Prize 2026 for his drawing, *Mark*. He says that portraits are an endless source of inspiration. Each additional one he works on is unique and presents a new challenge: a universe unto itself. ***Instagram: @sergejdraskovicart***

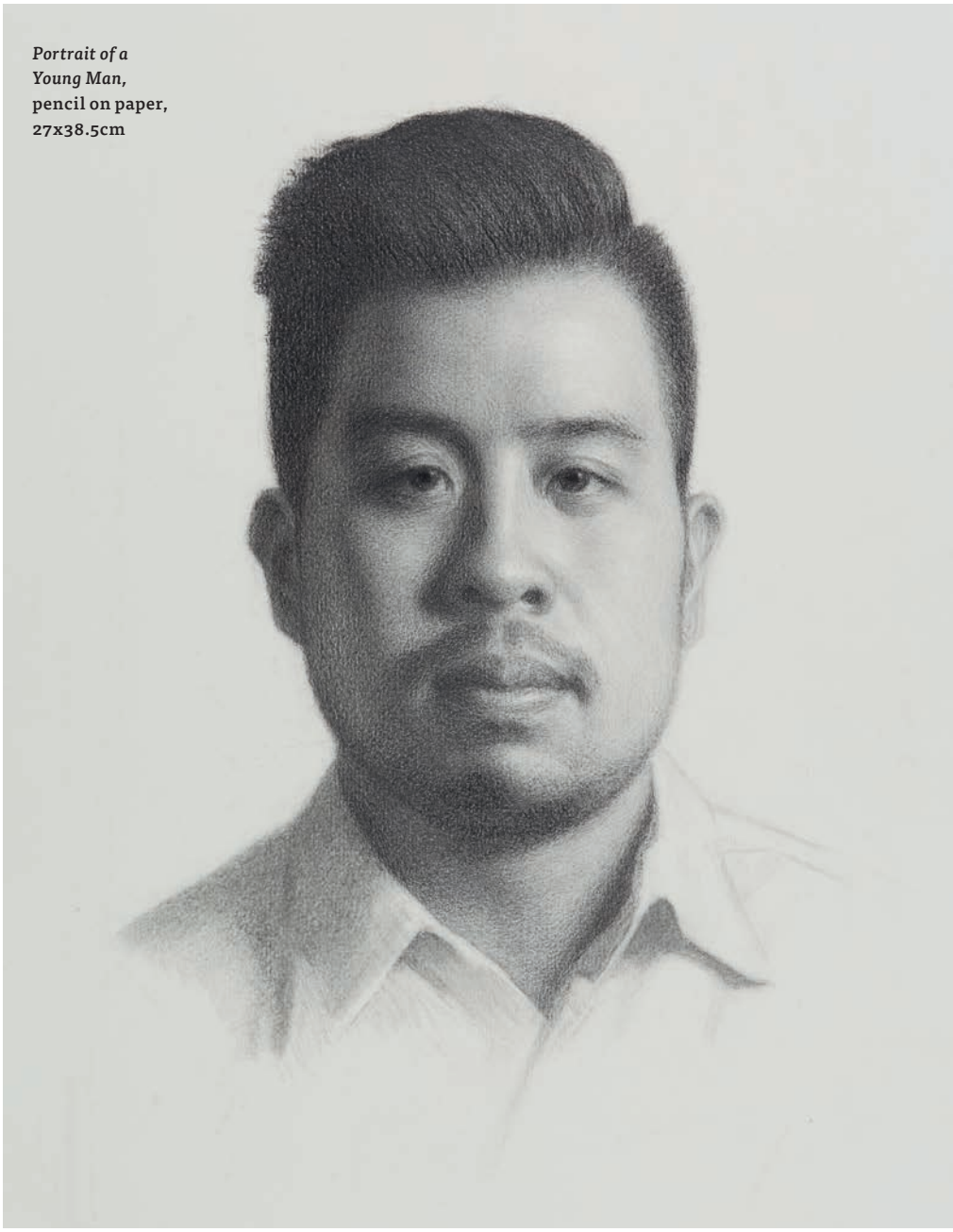
Drawing a human face from life seemed almost magical to me, but also intimidating.

I didn't dare try for a long time. Portraiture is still a challenge for me, and I feel a strong desire to keep deepening my knowledge and skills in that area. At the moment, I work in two main drawing modes: graphite on white or cream paper, and drawings on toned paper using graphite, white pastel and carbon pencils to achieve the deeper dark values. ▶



Mark, pencil on paper, 25x32.5cm

I didn't receive the classical training in portrait drawing I needed for the realism I was aiming for.
During the pandemic, I searched online for every possible resource to fill those gaps. One of the most important discoveries was Raw Umber Studios, with its excellent library of photo references and large number of tutorials led by very good instructors. Because I value Raw Umber Studios so highly, it is a great honour for me that they decided to award me this prize with my portrait, *Mark*. Taking part in competitions is important because it allows an artist to see their work in a broader context and gain insights that can help their further development. Although this is the first competition I have won, in others I have been both longlisted and shortlisted, and have discovered artists whose work I found very inspiring.



Portrait of a Young Man, pencil on paper, 27x38.5cm

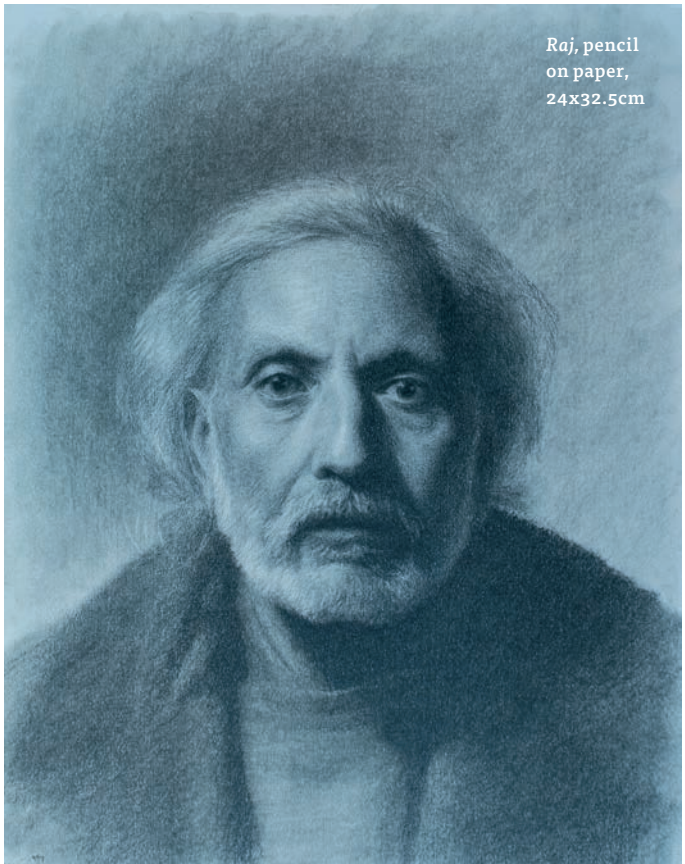
Capturing the 'soul' of a sitter is the closest thing to magic in the process of drawing a portrait.
At first, the drawing is abstract and geometric; I search for the right composition, proportions, a sense of character and likeness. It often doesn't look promising, and I feel I might not succeed. But if I stay with it long enough, there is a moment when it seems to come to life. For me, the ideal is working from a live model, but family life, working from home and the nature of commissions have meant I now rely more on photographs. I had to learn how to use them properly, because my earlier attempts from photos always looked flat and stiff.

I definitely belong to the group of messy artists.
I have tried to keep everything tidy and in order, but quickly it all slips back into a state of creative disorder. My pencils end up piled on top of one another, drawing boards are stacked in layers, and sketchbooks are in loose piles all around me. It is not complete chaos, but a kind of mess in which I personally navigate quite well. What matters to me is that the drawing itself is organised and clear, and everything I need is within reach. I am the only one who knows which pencil is where in those piles (most of the time) and which sketchbook with a particular paper is in which stack.

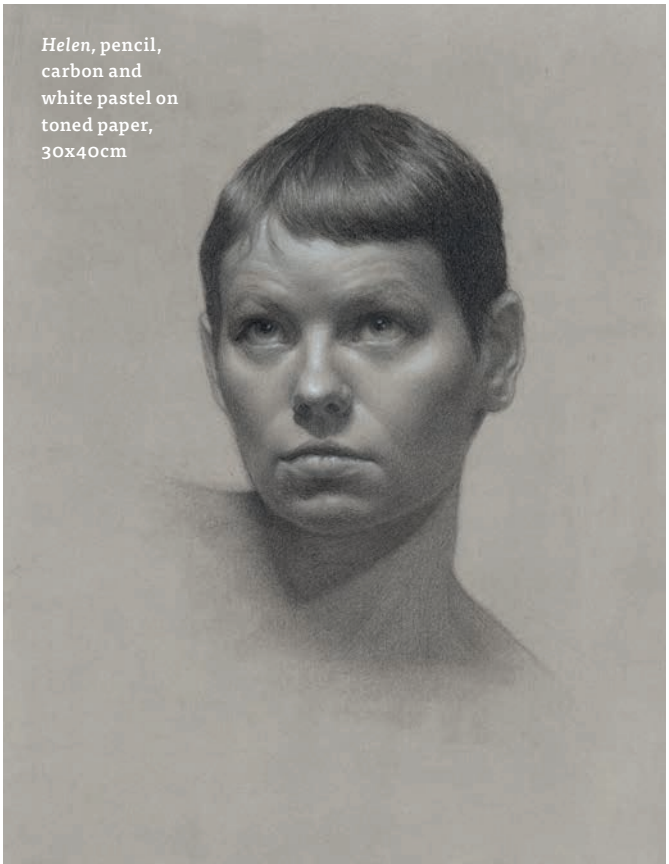
I regularly analyse the work of painters from the past.
I continually discover new artists or new works by painters I thought I knew. Sometimes paintings and drawings I have known for a long time suddenly appear completely different to me. Recently, for example, I saw some reproductions of works by Titian and Tintoretto and it felt as if I was seeing their paintings and drawings in a new light. This shift is, of course, also connected to the gradual deepening of my own understanding through my practice.

On a blank sheet of paper, something can appear that feels alive, with its own personality and story.
Works emerge that other people respond to, and which I myself often could not have imagined in advance, because they gradually take shape through the process of making them. Sometimes I start a drawing as a simple, informal exercise, but the process carries me further. Another rewarding aspect of this vocation is that I am constantly learning, always striving to grow and to deepen my understanding and skills. When people look at my work, I would like them to pause for a moment and slow down, as if the drawing opens up a small space of silence and stillness in the middle of everyday life – not only the physical likeness, but also something of their inner story. If the drawing encourages them to think more deeply about themselves and other people, then the work has fulfilled its purpose. □

Juno, pencil on paper, 30x30cm



Raj, pencil on paper, 24x32.5cm



Helen, pencil, carbon and white pastel on toned paper, 30x40cm

Morning Light in the Studio, oil, 71x76cm

Haidee-Jo Summers

This artist's work features fresh and vibrant brushwork coupled with keen drawing and observational skills. The results are lively, celebratory paintings that glow with light and sing with colour. *Niki Browes* gets a deeper insight ▶

Trifles and Treasures, oil, 41x30cm

There's One Here Somewhere, oil, 51x61cm

AWARD-WINNING ARTIST, Vice President of the Royal Institute of Oil Painters and elected member of the Royal Society of Marine Artists, Haidee-Jo Summers describes her work as "a celebration of light-filled moments revealed in rich and vibrant oil". Her biggest influence throughout her art practice was the acclaimed artist Ken Howard, who used to say that painting is about three things: communication, revelation and celebration. Haidee is also firmly of the desire to uplift people through her *en plein air, alla prima* work, whilst her main inspiration is the effect of light on a subject – and it is this which she salutes.

Light, she believes, has the ability to transform even the most mundane and ordinary subject into something magical. She finds joy in surprising people when they are emotionally stirred by an everyday scene she created – washing on a line, a jumbled garage workshop or an unmade bed – that they might never have thought to previously stop, appreciate and admire.
haideejo.com

I had a grandfather who painted marine subjects in oils.
He had to set up his easel in a tiny porch at the back of the house because the paints weren't allowed inside. I don't remember ever watching him paint but I do remember the smell of the linseed oil, and that he used to encourage all of us grandchildren to draw.

After I graduated in 1994 [from Leicester's De Montford University with a degree in Illustration] I started exhibiting my work straight away whilst returning to university part time to teach life drawing.
My first set of oil paints was from a prize I won on *The Big Breakfast*. The first prize was a wooden studio easel and a case of oil paints. I didn't have a clue how to use them! But that one event changed the whole course of my career. I started using them to paint portraits of friends and, around that time, I realised I didn't want to be an illustrator, but a fine artist.

I used almost all drawing and painting mediums along with printmaking when I was younger, and then eventually I found that I was focusing on oils as my primary medium.
Oils offered everything I felt I needed and were easy to frame, too. In recent years, I have reconnected with gouache and absolutely love it, as studies for studio oil paintings and as collectible paintings, which are more affordable than the oils. I'm only just beginning to exhibit them again, though I also sell them unframed on my website. As for experimentation, I think that inevitably your work changes with time and I embrace new directions and interests. I hope I will always be growing and developing, I think of it as becoming more honest and more succinct in delivery and my paintings reflecting more strongly who I am.

The Geese at Cadgwith Cove, oil, 41x51cm

Roses and Stocks, oil, 71x76cm

Fresh and direct brush marks are my personal visual language.

For the last 15 years or so I've particularly focused on *en plein air* painting, and this has necessitated a faster way of working. Most of my work is painted *alla prima*, on location, in three hours or less. I always say that painting with a time pressure helps an artist to become more decisive, and I think that comes across in bravura brush marks. I've always been fascinated by the relationship between the illusion of realism and three dimensionality of the depicted subject on the one hand and the nature of the abstract colours and marks on the picture surface on the other. Paintings where I can see evidence of the personality of the artist at work evidenced in the brushstrokes hold far more appeal to me than a carefully blended or polished finish.

I decided early on in my career that I didn't want to be a portrait painter. I felt that working to commission didn't really suit my personality. ▸

Dinner at the chateau de Puy Vidal, oil, 41x30cm

Yet, I have an enduring fascination with human faces and bodies, and so I have never stopped sketching them. I do want to include more figures in my work and have been moving in this direction in recent years because it does strike me as strange that my sketchbooks are full of people while my paintings are largely unpopulated. I want to close this gap.

Cornish Range at Cadgwith, oil, 41x41cm

When we see a painting of a room, we think about who uses that space and how?

Or we picture ourselves curled up in the cosy armchair, surrounded by family and pets. A room is really like a portrait of the person who lives there, we see all of their choices about decoration and the objects they like to surround themselves with, how they make themselves comfortable and where they relax or eat or work.

My new book on painting with oils is more of a 'why not?' than a 'how to' book.

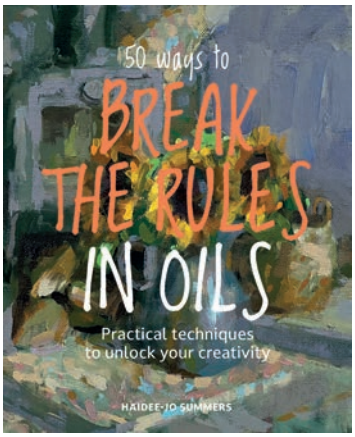
Washing Line by the Apple Tree, oil, 36x41cm

The idea came about through seeing how art students will sometimes tie themselves up in knots with painting theory. Confusion abounds when they have learnt certain methods in one studio and then go on to study under a different artist who seems to have an entirely contradictory approach. It can be hard to let go of the system you already know, to embrace the new method. But in truth painting isn't black or white, right or wrong, and an essential aspect of creativity is not being afraid to fail.

I have a recognition of when the painting is giving me what I was trying to communicate and so, need to finish. I tell my students, 'say what you want to say in the painting, then get out.' There is no use chattering on after you have made your point.

There are occasions when I have to abandon an *en plein air* painting before I've resolved it.
I really try to get them finished on site though, because I dread them coming back to the studio and joining the pile of 'unfinisheds'. I can be very tenacious about it. Those that do come back unresolved usually end up being directly painted over with a still life or interior in the studio, because I really enjoy having existing colours and shapes to start a fresh painting on top of. For me, it's very stimulating.

I feel a bit sheepish when people think I work all the time because I'm actually pretty good at relaxing.
Having said that, I think of painting as my vocation rather than as work, so there's no question of needing a break from it. When I get asked 'Don't you ever take a holiday?' I'm always a little taken aback as to me, what I do is neither work or holiday, but just a way of being, which fortunately has been the golden thread running through everything for as long as I can possibly remember. It may not be the best way to make a living, but it's a wonderful way to make a life. □



50 Ways To Break the Rules in Oils by Haidee-Jo Summers, £15.99, available at Search Press and all good book stores

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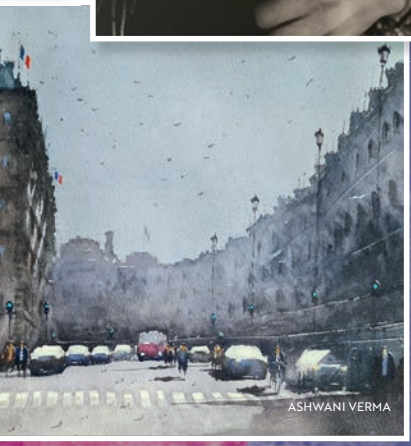

Meet the judges!

Our annual art competition goes from strength to strength and attracts entries by the thousands every year. With prizes galore – and unmatched press coverage for winners and finalists – we hand you over to the judges

What they're looking for

GARY ARMER (BRITISH ART PRIZE WINNER 2022)

"I'm hoping to see something that feels distinctive, work that has its own voice and doesn't blend into everything else. Technical skill is important, along with a strong, imaginative idea."

NEIL DAVIDSON (OWNER OF RAW UMBER STUDIOS)

"I will be looking for strong technical skill but also goes beyond that and has an emotional punch. A painting stands out if it gives me an initial 'wow' moment, and then when I look closer, I discover more depth in both what the artist has created and how they have achieved it."

KATE GARNER (MD OF EXACLAIR)

"I want to see originality, confidence of expression and a clear artistic voice, work that feels considered and intentional, whether it's bold or quietly nuanced."

KELVIN OKAFOR (LIFE LIKE PENCIL ARTIST)

"Authenticity, emotion and a strong sense of intention is what I'll be looking to identify. Work that feels honest and considered, especially when there is a clear connection between the artist and their idea."

TIFFANY PANTER (FOUNDER OF PANTER & HALL)

"I am drawn towards originality, a well-resolved composition and I admire artists who demonstrate a keen mastery of observation. It's about colour and texture; they're what really make a piece come alive."

JASON ASHWOOD

SARAH J MOON (PORTRAIT & FIGURATIVE ARTIST)

"For me, it's work that combines technical fluency with a strong sense of individual voice. I'm particularly interested in paintings with accuracy and skill, where the formal decisions feel purposeful and aligned with the underlying idea or theme."

CRISTINA SCHEK

ESTELLE LOVATT (ART CRITIC & HISTORIAN)

"I enjoy exploring the space between the representational and non-figurative, not settling in any one creative style. As most exciting art blends visual elements from reality with personal expression, that sometimes means artists alter, remove and add effects to make their artwork the best painting it can be."

NIKI BROWES (EDITOR, *ARTISTS & ILLUSTRATORS*)

"I want to see flair and real imagination; something unique delivered with passion and confidence." □

James McNeill Whistler

Considered to be the first contemporary artist, **JAMES MCNEILL WHISTLER**, shocked Victorian society with his avant-garde ideas and how flagrantly he courted attention, says *Martha Alexander.* But under the showmanship was a serious painter who was ahead of his time, as a major retrospective at Tate Britain is set to lay bare

"I'M NOT ARGUING, I'M TELLING YOU". If ever an utterance perfectly summed up its utterer, it's surely this, attributed to James McNeill Whistler, the artist who disrupted Victorian society with his experimental theories and methods. Widely considered to be the first ever contemporary artist, he was a nomad, an aesthete, a celebrity before celebrities were conceived and a trailblazer who was absolutely passionate about painting.

This quote is to be printed across a wall inside Tate Britain, accompanying some 150 of Whistler's works in what is the most significant European retrospective of his painting in 30 years. As well as his most famous paintings and etchings, including his *Nocturnes* series and the iconic portrait of his mother, a number of his sketchbooks will be opened to the public for the first time.

The show will open in a recreation of Whistler's studio in London's Chelsea, surrounded by his tools ▶

MUSÉE D'ORSAY, PARIS, FRANCE

Arrangement in Grey and Black No.1, 1871

ART INSTITUTE OF CHICAGO

ABOVE *Portrait of Dr. William McNeill Whistler*, 1871-73 **RIGHT** *Wapping*, 1860-4
BOTTOM LEFT *Nocturne: Black and Gold – The Fire Wheel*, 1875-7 **BOTTOM RIGHT** *Nocturne: Blue and Gold – Battersea Bridge*, 1872-5

including his easel, palette and Asian artefacts, as well as four self-portraits from various points in his life, bringing visitors face-to-face with the artist himself.

Born in Massachusetts in the summer of 1834, Whistler spent much of his life continent hopping. As a child he lived in St Petersburg where his father, also James, a civil engineer, had been commissioned by Tsar Nicholas to build Russia's first major railway. At 21, having returned to America in his late teens, he arrived in Paris determined to forge a career as a painter, befriending Impressionists Edgar Degas and Edouard Manet. His midlife was spent in London, butting heads with the art establishment while the winter of his life was spent travelling Europe and North Africa, creating ever more abstract etchings, lithographs and paintings.

For Carol Jacobi, the show's curator, it was important that Whistler is shown in an international context. "In the past he's been presented as a European artist, but we've exploded that and are showing work he did as a child in St Petersburg, in his sketchbook from that time as well, as another [sketchbook] from the end of his life in Algiers." His sketchbooks are tiny: they fit in the palm of a hand.

She also points out that while it was fashionable among bohemian Victorians to admire and collect objects from across Asia, Whistler appreciated the design principals, particularly of Japanese art, to such an extent that they began to show up in his work. "His art stopped looking European very quickly," she notes.

However, it was in Paris that his interest in working class life first piqued (despite his own bohemian sensibilities) and he would continue to document it for his entire career.

The biggest draw in the show is likely to be *Arrangement in Black and Grey: Portrait of the Painter's Mother* (1871). Jacobi suggests visitors should consider it in the context of an earlier family portrait in the show, *At the Piano* (1858-59), which was painted a decade earlier and depicts Whistler's half sister and her daughter. "It's Impressionist in its technique, it could have been painted by Manet," says Jacobi. "It's not stuck like a detailed

NATIONAL GALLERY OF ART, WASHINGTON

TATE

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picture can be: it's got liveliness to it. If you put it next to [the painting of his mother] you can really see how in 10 years Whistler completely revolutionised painting. He's moved on from Impressionism and yet the portrait of his mother was painted before the first Impressionist exhibition."

Jacobi points to the interior design of Whistler's studio where his mother, Anna, poses: no wallpaper ("very unusual for a middleclass Victorians: only working-class people and warehouses had painted walls"), no gold frames, no nicknacks, kimono curtain, geometric rug. "It's like something out of the 1920s," she notes. "I think that's one of the strangenesses of it. You've got this Victorian woman with a little cap on sitting in a really cool modern space."

Jacobi also observes how Anna is ▶

TATE

facing the wrong way, that is to say the opposite way to his sister at the piano. "There's a sense that she's in the future looking into the past," explains Jacobi. "What she's looking at is the curtains which for Victorians meant the departed. She's in mourning because her husband, Whistler's father, died young. She also lost children so she had had had a hard life but was a battler. I think this painting was a tribute to his family."

For Jacobi, the biggest discovery of her curatorial work for the show was understanding what a workaholic Whistler was: "He was incredibly productive: up in the morning, wandering around Chelsea (a rundown part of London in those days) as the shops opened and sketching in a little book or on an etching plate he kept in his pocket."

He'd produce paintings from these sketches and was always committed to a very spontaneous look.

"Some painters really show off their labour – look at the pre-Raphaelites – but Whistler wanted to look effortless," says Jacobi. "He worked hard to get the effect that his paintings had been breathed into being with no sign of labour." This meant erasing his work and going over it repeatedly.

"He was making paintings that are barely there by the end of his life – they are like vapour," says Jacobi, citing *The Lady in the Yellow Buskin* (1883) as a prime example. "She is almost disappearing, but he spent years and years on that."

Visitors will no doubt be drawn to the collection of his *Nocturnes* which in musical terms means quiet, possibly gloomy melody (he often gave his works musical titles – showing how important he found tonal harmony) which he created in the 1870s. These paintings were depictions of cities including Valparaiso in Chile, Venice in Italy and of course London at night, where he turned the warehouses and gardens that lined the river into glimmering masterpieces. However, these once proved controversial.

Whistler was provocative and often aggressive (in 1890 he published *The Gentle Art of Making Enemies* which was essentially a compilation of some of the greatest ripostes he'd ever served his rivals). He had a long-standing feud with Oscar Wilde, who was initially impressed and influenced by Whistler's witty badinage. However, when they fell out, their friendship descended into trading

ART INSTITUTE OF CHICAGO

LEFT *Symphony in White, No. 2. The Little White Girl*, 1864 **ABOVE** *The Artist in His Studio*, 1865-66

mocking insults with one another via letters to the newspapers.

Because of this gregarious, droll and combative streak (that he savvily realised could translate into publicity) Whistler's serious commitment to painting – and what he believed painting should be – is easy to overlook.

His creative philosophy was uncompromising, going against the grain of accepted norms in Victorian society, whose understanding of painting was that it should convey religion or history. Essentially, he believed that art should exist without sentimentality, "for art's sake;" relevant and interesting even without meanings or morals concealed in the brushstrokes. He was about sensuality rather than clear narrative: concerned with shape and shade. "Art should be independent of all clap-trap – it should stand alone, and appeal to the artistic sense of eye or ear," he once wrote.

The Royal Academy would not show Whistler's work which precipitated his showing in the Grosvenor Gallery in 1877 along with other members of his more experimental cohort. The Grosvenor Gallery exhibition was reviewed by John Ruskin, a critic whose judgement was taken as fact and who claimed that Whistler was a "coxcomb" (a now near extinct adjective meaning vain and self-important). Ruskin also dismissed *Nocturne in Black and Gold – The Falling Rocket* (1875) as "absolute rubbish," accusing Whistler of "flinging a pot of paint in the public's face."

Needless to say, Whistler was having none of it and sued Ruskin for libel. Whistler won but gained only a farthing (a fraction of a pence in today's money) in damages: the entire lawsuit left his reputation and bank balance in shreds.

Despite the cost to both Whistler and Ruskin, the trial marked a sea change in the perception of art critics, raising questions about their veracity. What was once accepted as truth was now considered a matter of taste or opinion. It also placed Whistler as one of the very first artists who understood the power of scandal."His career can be understood at either side of the bankruptcy – but it didn't change his course," says Jacobi. "He was unrepentant and won people round to his point of view."

Of course he did!

James McNeill Whistler, Tate Britain, 21 May to 27 September 2026. tate.org.uk □

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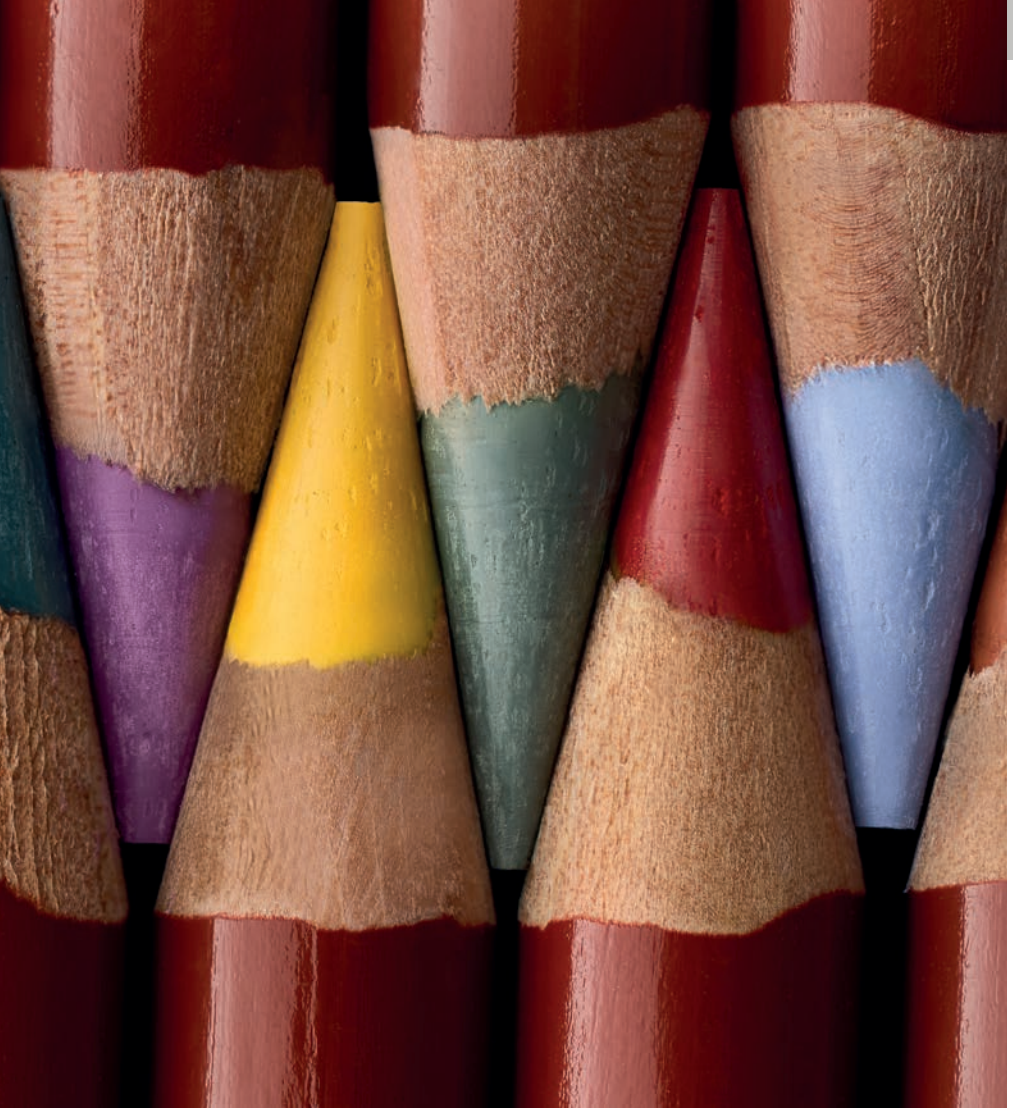

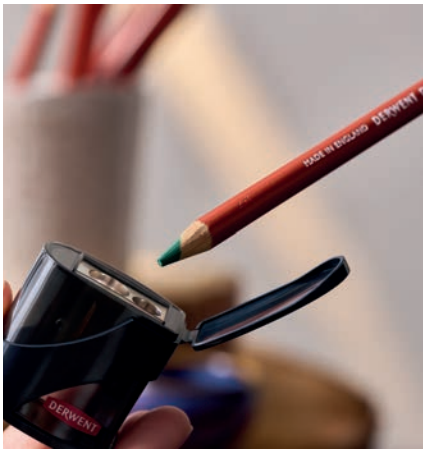

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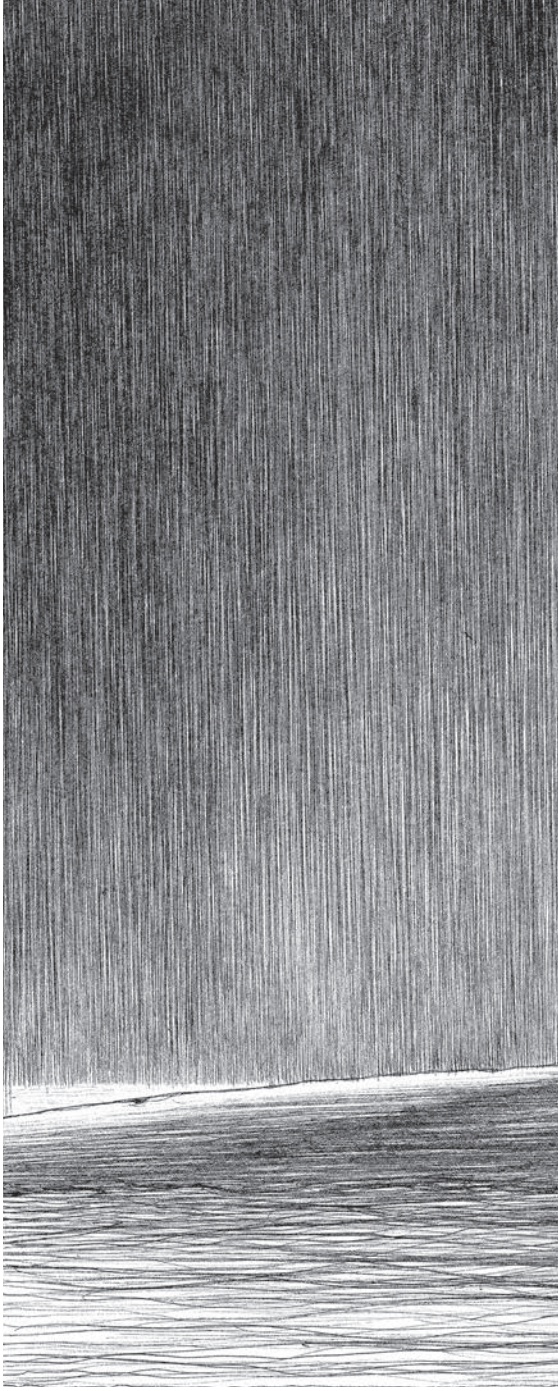
To those who speak

LUKE ADAM HAWKER was an architectural designer before becoming a full-time artist. He has just published *To Those Who Speak*, a best-selling book documenting, through words and drawings, the five-year period after the birth of his non-verbal son, Harry. By *Sarah Edghill*



Luke Adam Hawker, has always believed that. when words fail him, images come. "There are times in life, memories both good and bad, that I would struggle to put into words," he says. "To pinpoint exact emotions would feel too daunting, so I turn to drawing and my art to express them."

Having drawn from a young age, he graduated from university and worked as a designer, also beginning to draw for pleasure, spurred on by his love of architecture. "I started using my evenings, lunchbreaks and weekends to fill up sketchbooks around London," he explains. "For me, drawing has always felt like a safe space; a practice that made me feel at home in a city in which I had previously felt quite alien. I started selling my architectural work at markets and craft fairs, built a website, and eventually my income through selling my artwork reliably covered my rent. At that point, I quit my job as a designer and threw myself fully into my artistic career. I would go out with my easel, drawing day after day, building up my body of work nearly exclusively with architectural studies, but all drawn from life."

Luke's pen and ink work is so finely detailed that people are surprised by how quickly it's produced. "I think this is a by-product of being on location," he explains. "Six hours drawing in the studio is not six hours drawing from life, where you're constantly moving and observing. Drawing on location, you tend to lose track of time, and that's when you know you're doing something right. The longest I've ever drawn continuously for is around 12 hours. The focus it demands sinks you into a meditative state where time is not really a consideration, at least not a conscious one."

Although he makes technical detail look easy, drawings don't necessarily come together immediately. "I'm not blessed with this gift of pinpoint accuracy from the first line," he explains. "My lines are searching and layered. I build up images over time and have learned that ▸

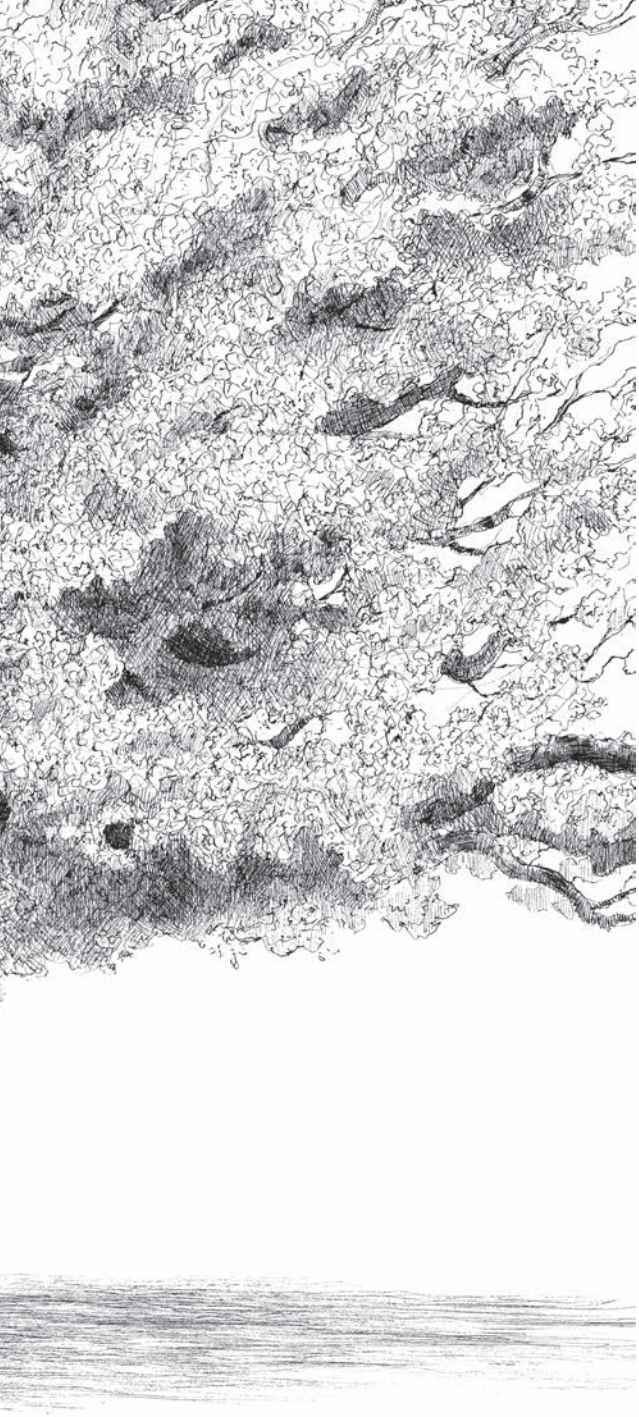
the most powerful artworks come from me when I focus on the desire to tell a story."

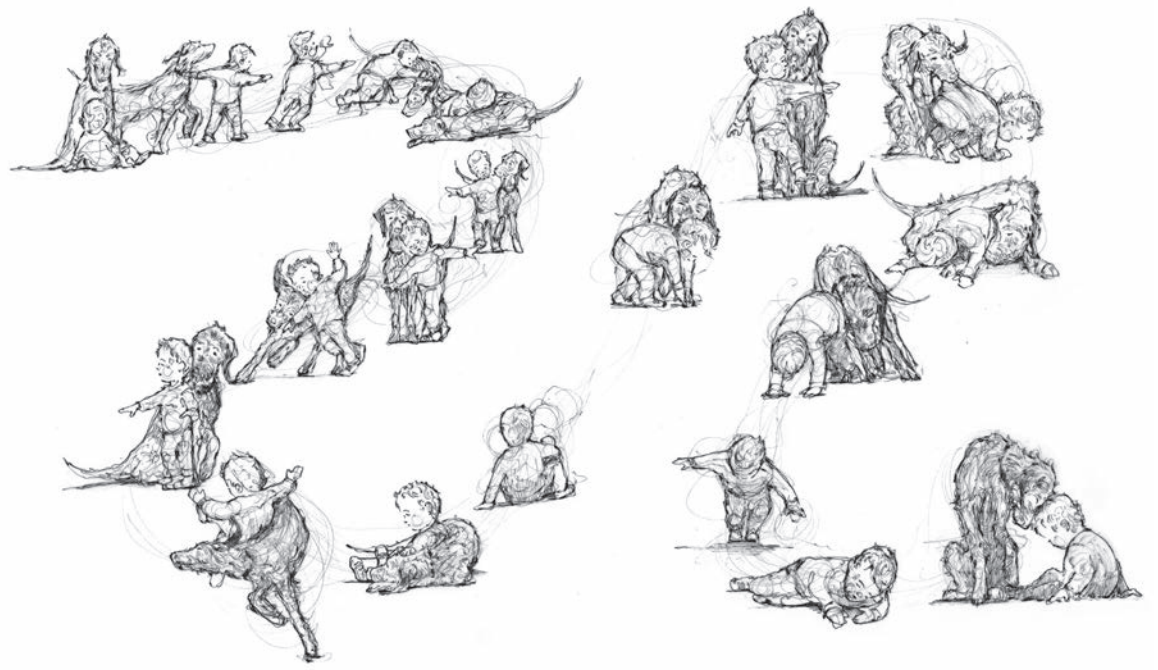
This is something Luke has done beautifully in his latest book, *To Those Who Speak*. His son Harry was born with an additional X chromosome and it soon became clear he was non-verbal and not reaching the expected developmental milestones. Respiratory problems led to prolonged hospital stays and immense anguish for Luke and his wife Lizzie, as they began to comprehend that family life wasn't going to be what they'd anticipated. The book charts the first five years of Harry's life: from pictures of him as a baby, through starting to walk and forging a bond with the family dog, Robin. It tells of the family's journey as they learnt that Harry's inability to communicate in a traditional way, didn't mean he wasn't speaking to them. In his dedication at the start of the book, Luke says: "My son has taught me more without words than every spoken conversation of my life so far."

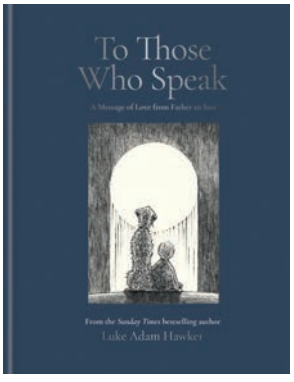
The book took more than three years to create. "I've never worked on a project that has lived so deeply in my mind and heart," says Luke. "It was incredibly inspiring, daunting and stifling all at once. Many sketchbooks later, the story of the book emerged in a way that made sense: ranging from a scene where we rush Harry to hospital, to the moon rising out of the ocean, this book is a look at, primarily, the feelings felt along the way."

Creating *To Those Who Speak* was the first time Luke had consciously used art as therapy. "I use my art to depict recollections, memories and feelings about what I've been through: the hardest, yet most fruitful years of my life. Using my son and my dog as protagonists, I was able to draw what felt like love and, in doing so, heal through that process."

Drawing, for Luke, is about so much more than capturing an image; it's all about connection. "My non-verbal son has helped me see and define what really I already knew deep down: that non-verbal communication is our universal mother tongue, humanity's first language; not something my family and son were forced to learn in addition to what we know, but something of an awakening to the power and magic held within the art of truly seeing, truly listening and – through art – perhaps truly speaking." ***lukeadamhawker.com*** □







To Those Who Speak is published by ILEX Press, £16.99

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Step-by-step studio

Each month we speak to a member of the British Art Club about their art practice, and how they get it done. Here, graphic portrait artist, **MARK SIMPSON**, shares his arty lifehacks and insights

1

CHOOSE YOUR PAPER CAREFULLY

It's essential for paper to have a subtle grain and be robust enough to accept layers of graphite without compromising the integrity. This texture and weight allows for the build-up of several layers of carbon and graphite, which is particularly important for achieving rich, dark tones.

2

AVOID GRAPHITE SHINE

This can be a by-product of pencil work. Rather than relying heavily on burnishing through pressure, I use small filbert brushes, which minimise unwanted shine and allow for smooth blending. This preserves the subtle textures within the piece but also enhances the overall depth and richness of the artwork.

3

EMBRACE YOUR MISTAKES

Each misstep offers valuable lessons and contributes to growth. It's important to remember that creating art should always be a source of joy. What seem like major errors to the artist, may be barely noticeable to others, making it all the more important to approach your work with a positive spirit.

britishartclub.co.uk/profile/simpsonart44

MALLARD DUCKLING, GRAPHITE PENCIL AND CARBON, 35X43CM

Everything in t

JANET MAYLED uses acrylic to paint an allotment where found objects shape the visual narrative

he garden

My artistic practice is rooted in my observation of everyday life, encompassing subjects such as landscapes, still life and urban scenes. Regardless of the subject matter, I seek out compositions designed to guide the viewer's gaze through the painting. This involves breaking down elements into patterns and directing the eye from one object to another using line, colour and form, whether it's the sweep of a fence, pattern of greenhouse frames or rhythm of flowerbeds.

Layering acrylic paint with Satin Medium to enrich texture and depth lies at the heart of my technique. Satin Medium can be used to create glazing effects, build soft passages of colour and enhance the tactile quality of the work. This evokes atmosphere – the dappled light of a greenhouse, a misty morning – while deepening spatial complexity.

In this scene, the composition unfolds with found objects repurposed by gardeners, which become structural anchors: greenhouses, beds and plant supports shape the visual narrative and serve as conduits for the viewer's gaze. In the foreground, the magnificent dahlias pull attention forward, while the distant houses beckons the eye deeper into the painting. On the right, two figures lean over a fence, guiding the gaze towards the heart of the story. ***janetmayled.com*** ▸

JANET'S MATERIALS

Acrylic Paints

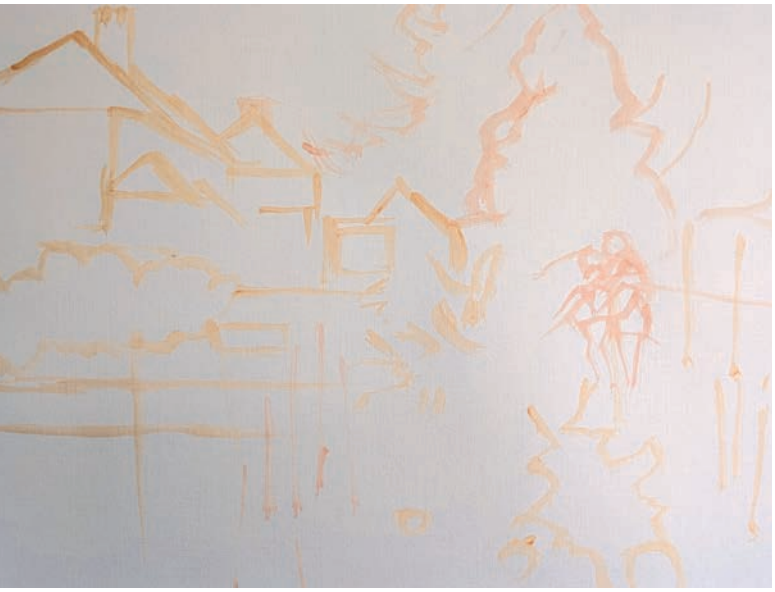
Jacksons Golden: Cobalt Blue, Quinacridone Magenta, Pyrrole Red
System 3: Cadmium Yellow, Fluorescent Red, Titanium White, Raw Umber
Amsterdam: King's Blue, Permanent Blue Violet
Winsor & Newton Galeria: Winsor Blue
Golden Satin Glazing Medium

Brushes

Artmaster Pearl Set: 2, 4, 6, 8,10,12
Artmaster Pearl Angled series 33: 6, 12
Daler-Rowney Short Flat ½"

Support

System 3 A3 acrylic paper



1 SKETCHING OUT

Sketch out the composition using acrylics. This initial stage is crucial for establishing the fundamental structure and guiding the overall layout of the painting. I take time to observe carefully what I want to record, whether working *en plein air* or in the studio, then sketch with a size 8 round watercolour brush, which allows me to use expressive lines to lay out my composition.

2 ORGANISE YOUR PAINTS

I use a deep-sided plastic nibble tray with divided compartments, where I place basic colours. I also use a plastic palette or tear-away paper palette for colour mixing. My goal is to create a palette of colours that work well together, mixed from primaries, secondaries and tertiaries.

3 FILL IN

Now block in the main forms and shapes, creating a base for further details. Using a ½" short flat square-edged brush, I fill in flat areas of the main shapes with lighter tones of what I observe. I start by mixing Cobalt Blue, Titanium White and a touch of Cadmium Yellow for the sky and also use this mixture within the windows. Then I proceed to the foreground. The aim is to fill the paper with jigsaw-like pieces before adding the next layer.

4 DARKER AREAS

Once the basic shapes are blocked in, I focus on building up the darker areas to add depth and contrast, enhancing the three-dimensionality of the painting. I mix Winsor Blue with Permanent Blue Violet for the shadows on the chimney and roof. The more distant house is left with a pale pink roof to add to the perspective, as it is further away.

5 THE GREENHOUSE

During the earlier blocking stage, I observed the colours through the greenhouse. Onto this I add, with a fine brush, detail of the three-dimensional structure using a broken line. Keeping the lines broken prevents the structure from appearing too solid or overpowering. Simple circles representing flowers are added at the base using oranges, purples and white, which helps create depth in the flower patch. ▶

6 WINDOWS AND THE CHIMNEY DETAILING

The brickwork of the house is suggested using Satin Medium, mixed with a darker russet hue to depict the texture. For the accents on the window frames, use Permanent Blue Violet, a touch of Cadmium Yellow and Titanium White to create a mauve-grey that matches the shadows on the roof and reflections in the windows. These marks build the surface and add overall depth and complexity.

7 ADDING MORE LAYERS AND MIXING GREENS

When observing trees and foliage, I often see blues and reds. For the background trees, I overpaint with a blue-green to suggest branches, using a mix of Quinacridone Magenta, Cadmium Yellow, Cobalt Blue and Titanium White. Using this colour thread, I then create a range of greens for the foliage in the foreground. The layering continues by adding, with white, outlines of discarded cold frames which are behind the fence on the right.

8 DEVELOPING THE FIGURES

These figures add some storytelling to the scene: they are engrossed in conversation. The light is directly onto their faces and I want to use limited brushstrokes to suggest the light on the caps and the shadow under the brim of the hat. I use a light Raw Umber with Satin Medium to suggest the glasses on the right-hand figure which also helps to define his nose shape.

9 FLOWER DETAIL

I work into the centre of the flowers with complementary tones, to suggest the petals and add depth and vibrancy to the composition. To get striking oranges and yellows, I use Fluorescent Red within my palette, which I can also use as a glaze with the Satin Medium, to accentuate the luminosity. For the grass in the flowerbed behind I use short brushstrokes to suggest the texture of the grass.

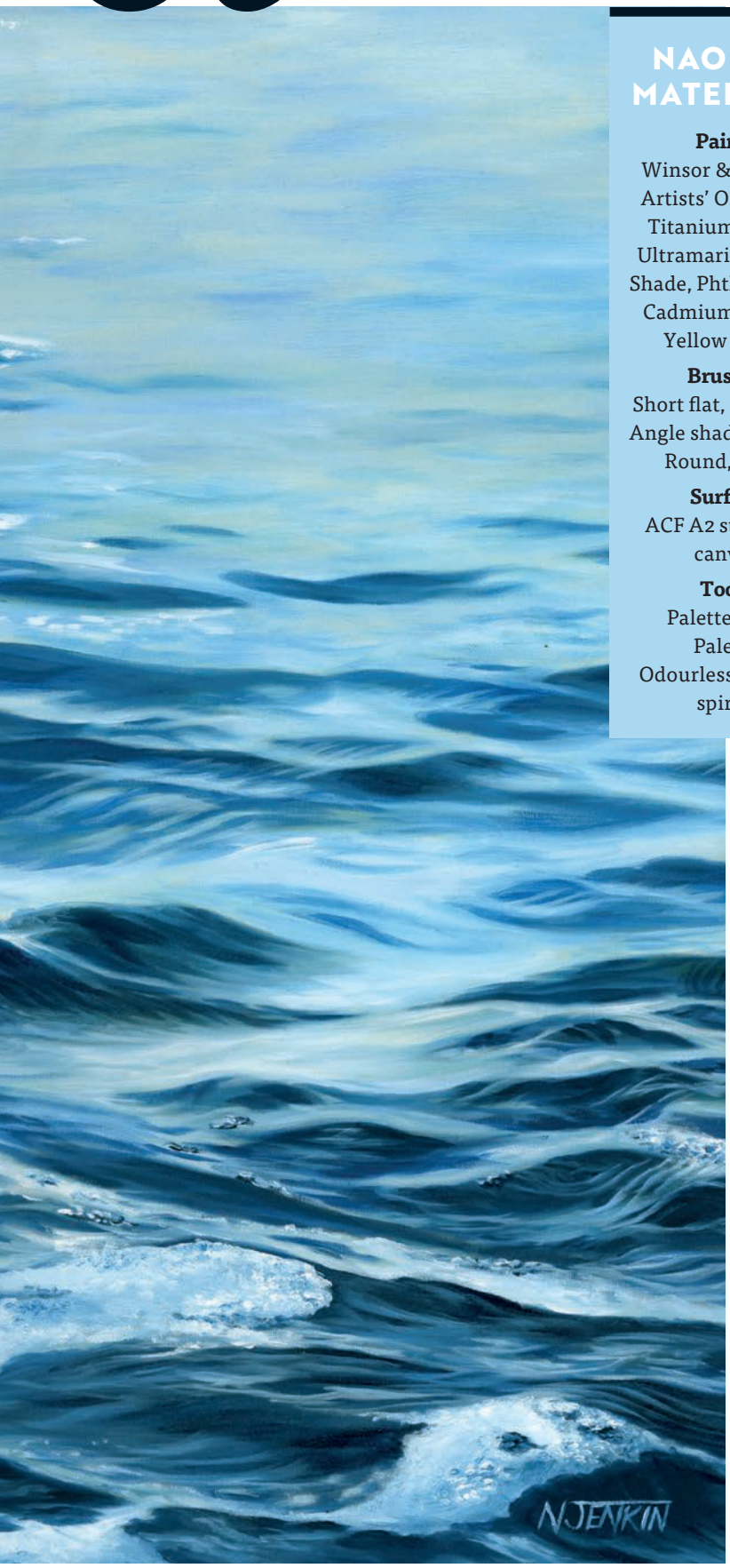
10 FINAL STAGES

So the painting is now almost finished. The final touches just involve highlighting the supports of the dahlias. To add depth to the finished painting, I have added a suggestion of distant tree shadows on the upper right side, using a brown tone which is also seen in the building. This helps to define the outline of the branches within the scene. □

Ripple effe

Ct

NAOMI JENKIN shows how to study light and movement to create an illusion of depth in a seascape in oils



NAOMI'S MATERIALS

Paints
Winsor & Newton Artists' Oil Paints: Titanium White, Ultramarine Green Shade, Phthalo Blue, Cadmium Yellow, Yellow Ochre

Brushes
Short flat, sizes 8, 12
Angle shader, size ¼
Round, size 3

Surface
ACF A2 stretched canvas

Tools
Palette knife
Palette
Odourless mineral spirits

THE OCEAN IS AN INCREDIBLY REWARDING SUBJECT to paint, yet many artists shy away from it. Water can feel intimidating: it has depth, constant movement, shifting reflections and endless, subtle changes of colour. Even calm water is alive with ripples and light. Yet once you begin to understand it, the sea becomes an endless source of inspiration: from dramatic, crashing waves to tranquil, glassy horizons. Paint is a particularly beautiful medium for capturing water. Its fluidity allows you to move it across the canvas, mimicking the way water moves in reality, which help the artist suggest motion, light and depth.

If you can, spend time observing water before you attempt to paint it. Visit the beach, a lake or even a pond, and simply watch. Notice how the surface shifts and flows. Observe the way sunlight filters through and reflects back at you. Study the patterns of ripples, the mingling colours, and the way submerged objects appear softened or distorted beneath the surface. This kind of observation will pay dividends when you begin your own painting.

In this tutorial, we'll start with a simple close-up study of calm ocean water, and you'll learn how to create the illusion of depth, suggest light dancing across the surface, and how to convey the feel of movement.

naomijenkinart.com ▸

1 PLAN YOUR COMPOSITION

I've used the rule of thirds to create a balanced, harmonious composition and the reference photo has been cropped so the top third remains fairly sparse and softly focused. This immediately introduces a sense of depth, allowing the eye to travel naturally towards the foreground. In contrast, the lower section is sharper and richer in detail, with darker ripples and delicate touches of foam that draw the viewer in. ▸

2 TONE THE CANVAS

Tone the canvas using Yellow Ochre diluted in odourless mineral spirits. This makes tonal values easier to judge than working on a white surface, and the warm undertone subtly glows through paint layers, giving a sunlit feel and helping the blues sing. Spread the wash over the canvas with the size 12 short flat brush and leave to dry for a few hours.

3 SKETCH THE MAIN ELEMENTS

I always find it useful to do this before I start painting. It helps me more easily navigate the whole subject, and it also means I can make sure I have the proportions and perspective of the composition right before I start layering on the paint. I use a graphite pencil to lightly sketch in the main elements on the canvas.

4 MIX THE COLOURS

For the dominant light blue, combine Phthalo Blue and Titanium White. For the sea blue, mix Ultramarine Green Shade and Phthalo Blue with a small amount of Titanium White and Cadmium Yellow. Create the darkest value first, then lighten a portion with more Titanium White to produce a midtone. Next, do the sea greens. Mix the darkest shade first using Ultramarine Green Shade and a touch of Cadmium Yellow. Lighten part of this mixture with Titanium White for the midtone. For the pale, muted green ripples in the top section, take a little of the midtone and add extra Titanium White. Finally, mix a sky blue for the sky reflections on the water's surface by using Ultramarine Green Shade and Titanium White.

5 BLOCK IN THE BLUE

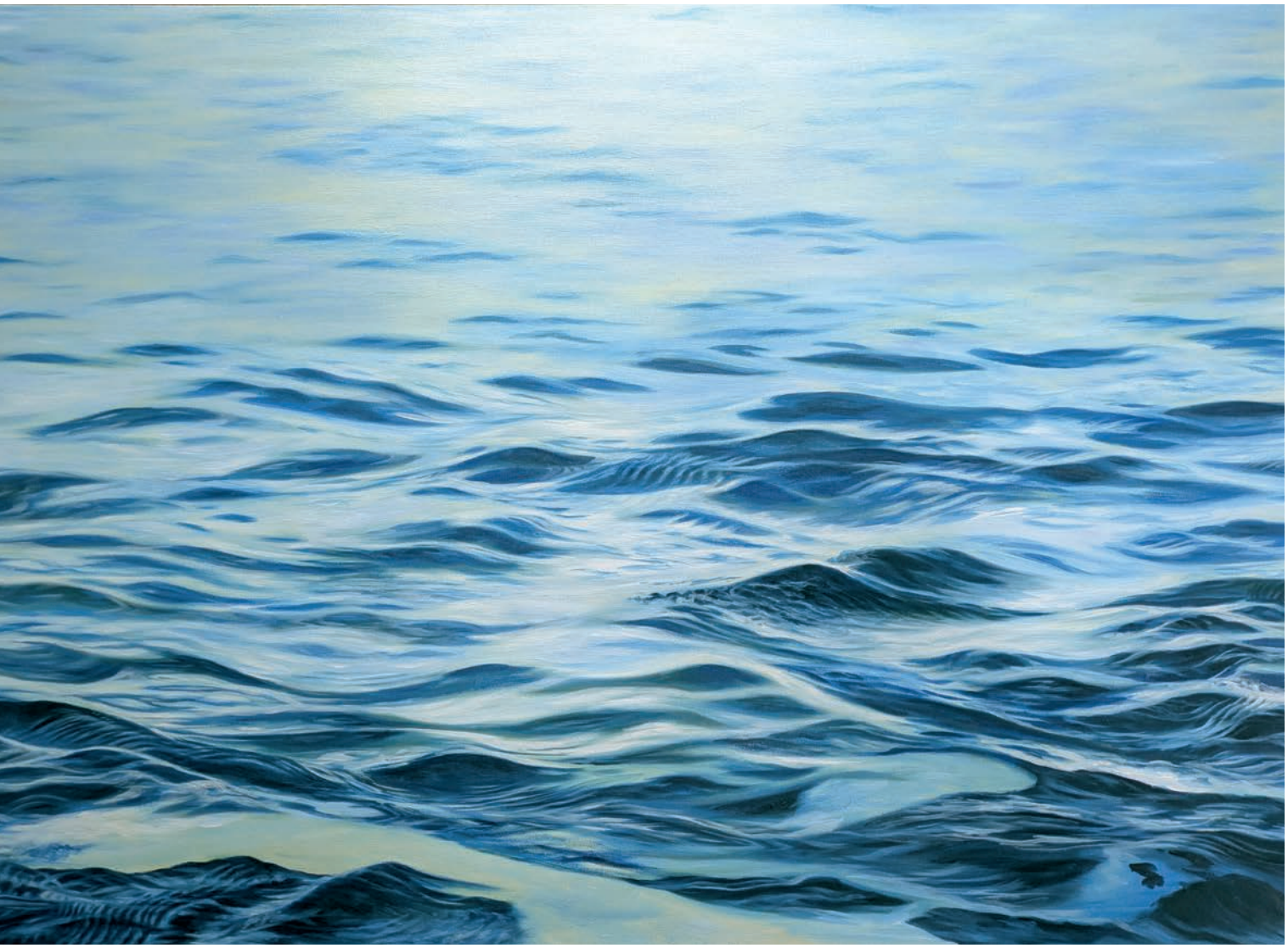
Block in the light blue areas using a size 8 short flat brush. Next, introduce the mid and dark sea blues to form the ripple shapes. Observe the flow and direction of the water in your reference, paying close attention to the changing size of the ripples. Those in the foreground should be larger and more defined, gradually becoming smaller towards the background to create a convincing sense of depth.

6 NOW FOR THE GREEN

Refer to your image to see where they appear – typically along the top crest of each ripple. Blend mid green into the mid blue areas, and dark green into the dark blue ripples to enrich the colour and add depth. ▶

7 WORK ON THE RIPPLES

In the top section, use the sky blue and lightest green to add small, subtle ripples, then introduce a few darker ripples using the sea blue midtone. Be guided by the reference photo for placement. Soften the whole area by lightly brushing side to side with the size 12 short flat brush. Moving down the rest of the canvas, pepper in a few more subtle sky reflections in the light blue areas.

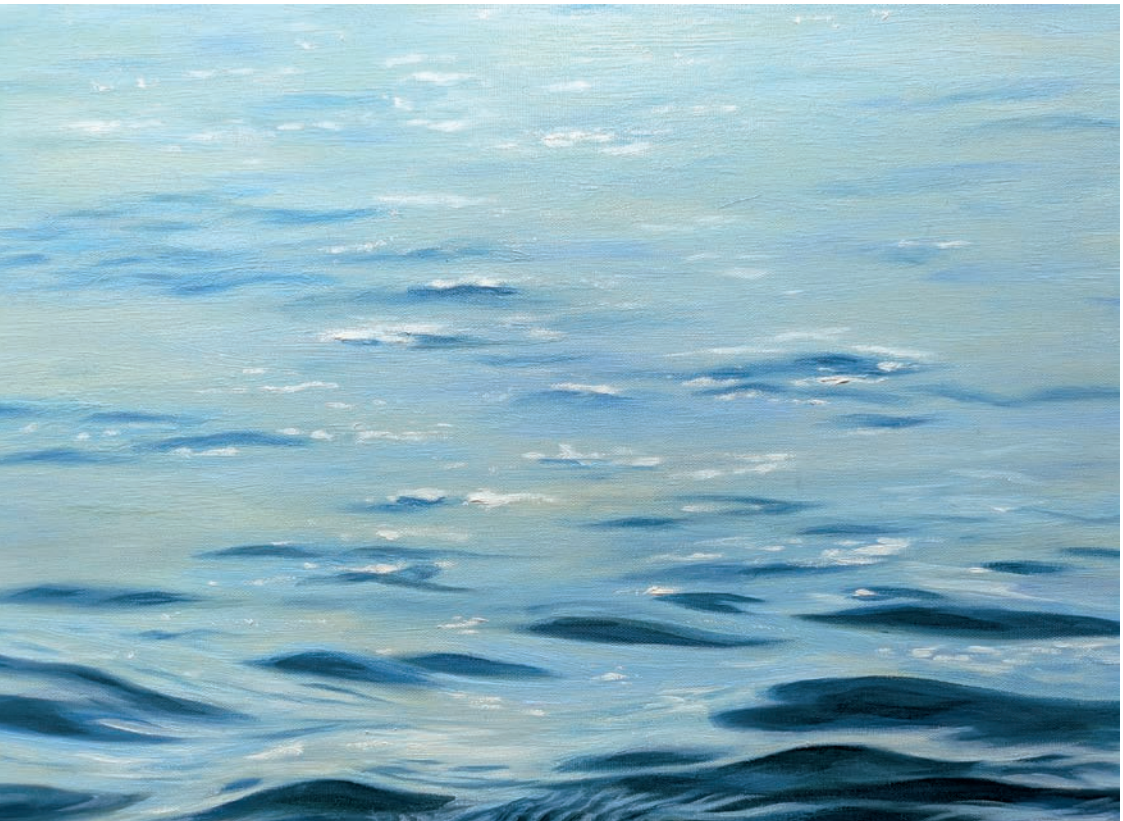


8 LAYER IN SOME FINER DETAILS

Observe the main ripples in the reference photo and notice the smaller, lighter ripples on their surface caused by a gentle breeze. Using the angle shader brush and a small amount of light blue, add in these subtle ripples. Follow the shapes and direction shown in the reference photo to convincingly convey the contours of the water's surface.

9 ADD THE FOAM TRAILS

Use Titanium White mixed with a touch of light sea blue to add these trails in the foreground. For the highlights, use pure Titanium White. Add in the bubble details in the foam with the size 3 round brush by lightly dabbing small circles of midtone sea blue. Then add some bright white highlights around them. There are also a few isolated areas of foam and bubbles dotted around in the foreground. Use the dark green shade to dab in the base of these bubbles first, then top with Titanium White. Keep them simple – you don't need much to create the illusion.



10 FINALLY, THE WHITE SPARKLES

For the sparkles of light reflecting off the surface, use pure Titanium White and the size 8 short flat brush. If you place some of these sparkles near the mid blue shade, the relative contrast between the two will make the white appear brighter and shine more. If necessary, you can darken the areas around where you want the brightest sparkles to appear.

And that's it! I hope this tutorial has given you the confidence to go and try your own paintings of water. □

MADE IN ENGLAND DERWENT DRAWING Mist 6730
MADE IN ENGLAND DERWENT DRAWING Mars Violet 6470
MADE IN ENGLAND DERWENT DRAWING Autumn Leaf 0600

DERWENT DRAWING 40TH ANNIVERSARY

Creating wool textures

Sometimes, it's exciting to be creative with your colours. **JESS PRITCHARD** creates this alpaca with warm hues, using the fabulous Derwent Drawing Pencil range, chosen for it's beautifully soft texture and nature inspired colour palette

For this step-by-step guide, I wanted to explore a natural texture in a way that felt both satisfying to draw and technically useful. This led me to focus on the dense, soft look of alpaca wool, as capturing fluffy, thick hair offers a great opportunity to demonstrate how layered pencil techniques can be used to build depth, movement and realism.

As a wildlife artist, I'm often drawn to subjects that allow me to really study texture and light. Alpaca wool has a slightly unpredictable quality to it that makes it especially interesting to capture. It encourages a more intuitive approach to mark-making, which I always enjoy. I also decided to bring in a wider range of colour than typically expected in a realistic animal portrait. Introducing different hues throughout the wool allows for a more expressive approach, while keeping the form of the alpaca believable. It's a nice way to show how colour can be used creatively without losing realism.

For this piece, I have used the Derwent Drawing Pencil range as it's well suited to this kind of study. Its nature-inspired palette lends itself beautifully to organic subjects such as animals, landscape and portraiture, while also offering the flexibility to push into more creative colour choices. I have used these pencils for years to draw a variety of animal portraits as they blend smoothly, making them ideal for building up soft textures like wool, whilst their high lightfastness ensures that finished pieces will stand the test of time.

pritchart.co.uk

JESS'S MATERIALS

Derwent Drawing Pencils

Mist,
Brown Ochre,
Light Rust,
Granite,
Ivory Black,
Soft Violet,
Mars Violet,
Yellow Ochre,
Autumn Leaf

1 THE OUTLINE

Begin by sketching a basic outline of your alpaca, adding details to key features such as a highlight for the eye and a nostril in the nose. Roughly block out sections on the alpaca's head and down the neck to signify where each colour in the wool will be placed. ▶

2 THE EYES

Using the colour Mist, cover the eye in smooth, circular motions while leaving the highlight of the eye clear and a wave along the top edge where the wool meets the eye. Then, using Brown Ochre in these same circular motions, place down the colour along the outer edge of the eye and release pressure as you work towards the centre. These colours will blend perfectly, thanks to the creamy nature of the pencils.

3 HIGHLIGHTS

Add a hint of Polar Ice to the eye highlight followed by a touch of Light Rust on the left and right of the eyeball. Fill the under eyelid and tear duct with Mist before adding the shading using Ivory Black. Begin with light pressure and increase in darker areas such as the pupil and strong shadows. Make sure you leave a little base colour showing through to give the eyeball shape.

4 FLICK!

In a flicking motion, put down a base layer of Mist over the face and ears, using the thick core of the pencil to easily cover this area. Tip: use your base layers to work out fur direction as a guide for top layers.

5 THE FACE AND EARS

Starting with Yellow Ochre, add a little colour to the shaded areas of the face and ears in thick strokes, following the fur direction of your base layer. Due to the beautifully high pigmentation of the pencils, you will only need light pressure. Repeat in the same areas by lightly using Granite for extra depth. Fill the inner ear and nostril with Granite before strengthening the darker shadows, nostril and inner ear with Ivory Black.

DERWENT
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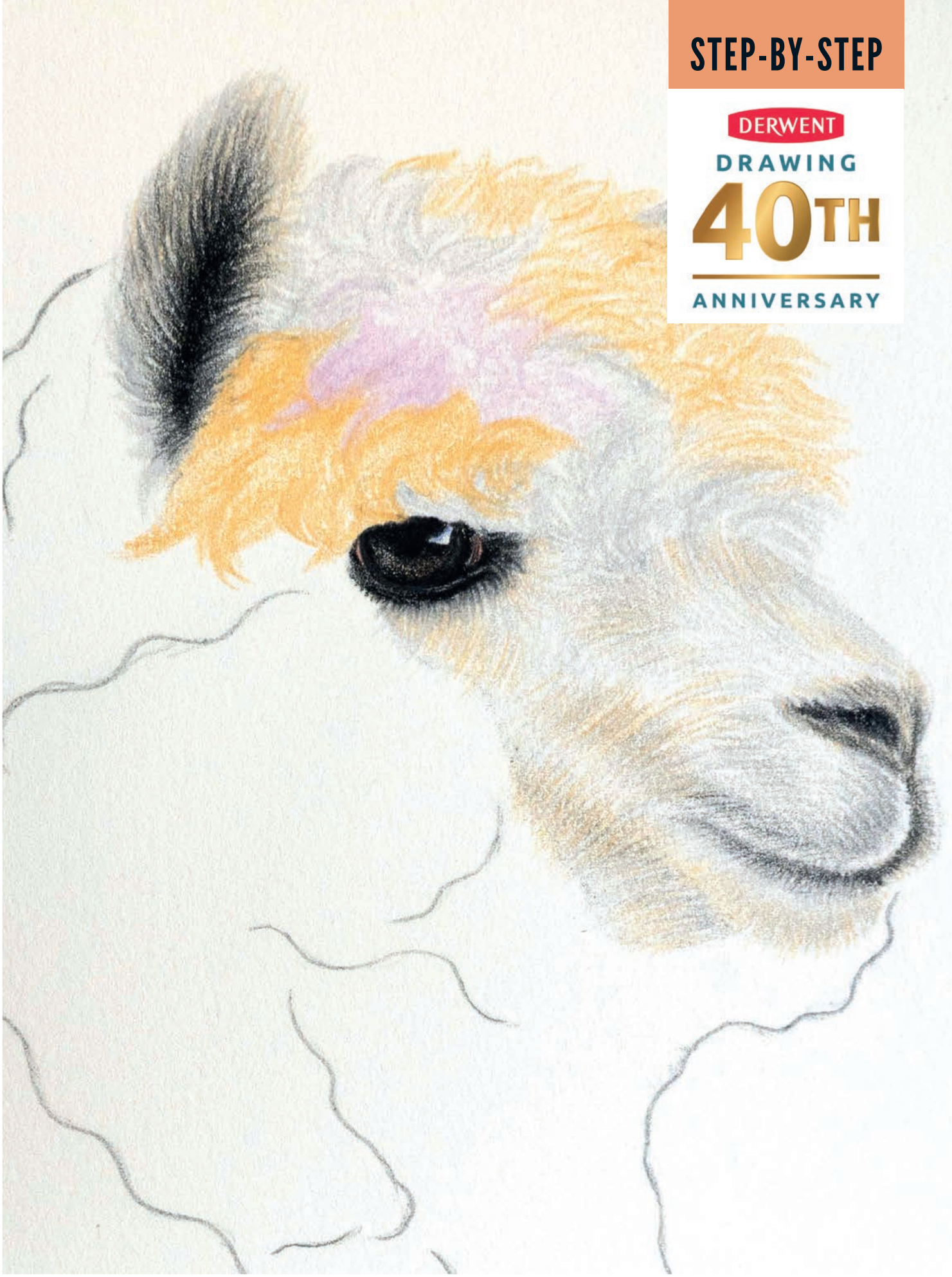
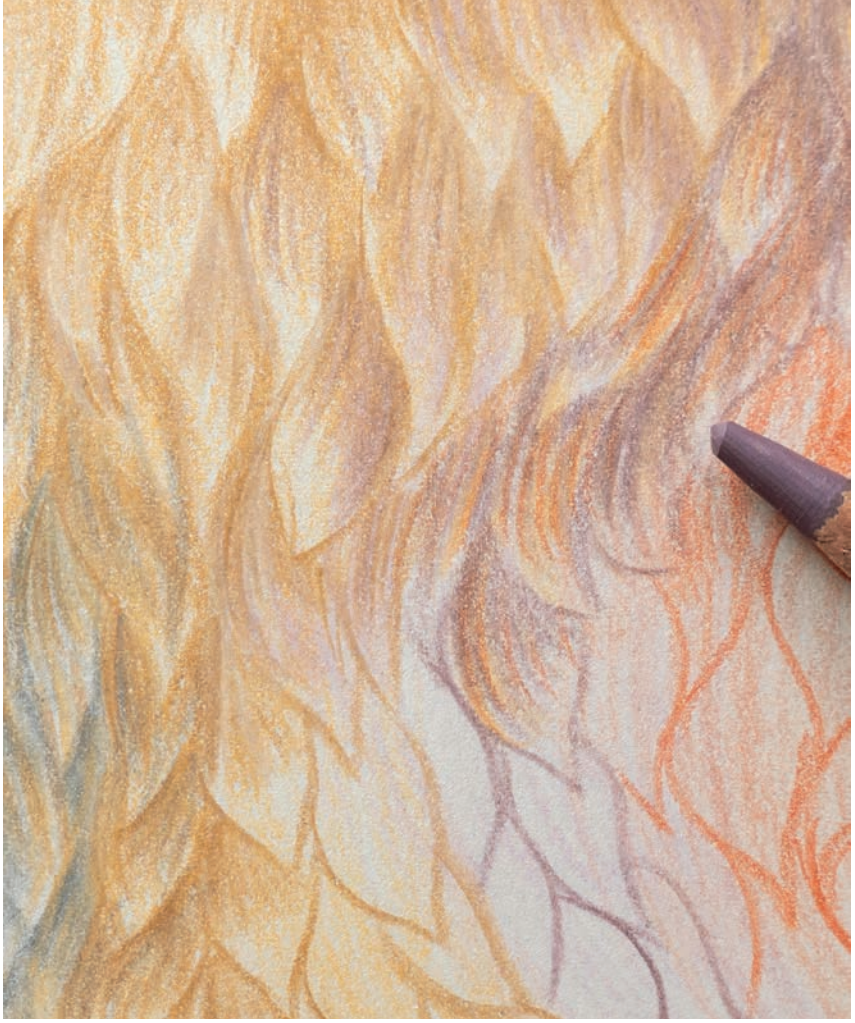


6 THE WOOL

Using the soft pencil core to your advantage, place down the base colours of the wool. Use wavy strokes to cover the area and map out the direction of the wool hairs. Make sure there are no straight edges along each colour section to give a flowing look. The base colours to use for each section are: Yellow Ochre, Grey, Mist, Orange, Light Rust, Purple, Soft Violet. ▶

7 SMALLER SECTIONS

Now your base colours are down, you can split each coloured section into smaller, wavy segments using darker tones. Pay attention to the general direction of the wool and remember, wool and hair aren't perfectly neat so don't be afraid to overlap some of the segments. The darker colours for each section are: Yellow, Brown Ochre, Grey, Granite, Orange, Autumn Leaf, Purple, Mars Violet.



DERWENT DRAWING 40TH ANNIVERSARY

8 FLUFF IT UP

Keeping hold of the same colours from the previous step, begin filling in each segment, adding shadows to the underlaps and along the edges. This helps create a thicker, fluffy look to the wool. Use the opaqueness of the pencils to layer light and dark colours from each section into neighbouring areas, softening transitions between colours. Begin each stroke with medium pressure and release at the end to achieve a gentle, graded effect.

9 MIX IT UP

To create additional wool texture, use the lighter base colour from each section around the outer edge of the alpaca to draw wavy, overlapping strands of wool and hair. Make sure you keep each strand at different lengths to prevent them from looking too uniform. Repeat this along the edge of each colour section inside the alpaca, this time using the darker shades for maximum impact over the layer's underneath.

10 NAME THEM!

Congratulations, you have created your very own fluffy alpaca! Don't forget to sign your work and give your alpaca a name. ***derwentart.com***

Get your free Derwent Drawing Pencil with the July issue of *Artists & Illustrators* at selected UK retailers □

Roadside attractions

ROGER'S MATERIALS

Watercolour paint
Winsor & Newton, and Holbein pigments

Brushes
Princeton long bristle liner brush
Winsor & Newton sable brushes
Percy Baker Brushes
W.A. Portman brushes

Support
Arches 300# hot press watercolour paper
Staedtler-Mars mechanical pencil, lead B
A selection of pastel pencils
Gum Arabic
White gouache
Hand-built plexiglass
Gouache palette
Chalk
iPad

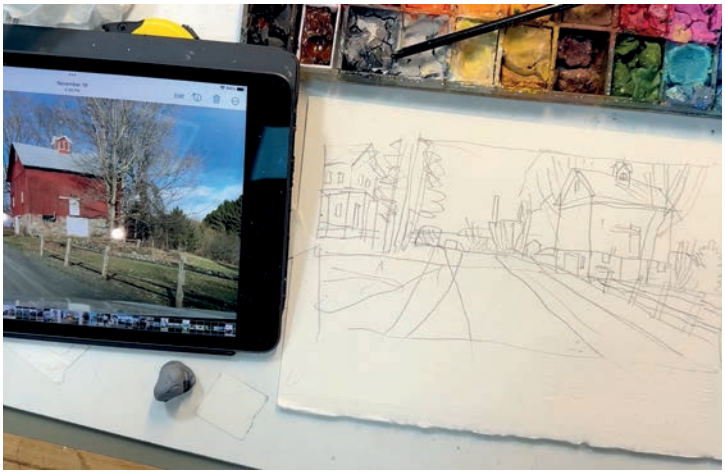
From historic homes, ancient farms and noteworthy architecture, **ROGER DE MUTH** has found painting small scale can be a lot of fun. Here, he shows you how he painted a village scene in New York state

With over 800 oil paintings and 500 plus watercolours in one small studio room, space is at a premium. I've had to reduce the size of my watercolour paintings, certainly because my desk area doesn't have much room, either. I've increasingly worked smaller and smaller to accommodate the tiny work area. What I've since found is the micro sized paintings are fun to work on.
rogerdemuthwatercolors.com ▸

STEP-BY-STEP

1 THE IMAGE

I work closely with my iPad at my side, which is indispensable for photo reference. For detailed work, I can zoom in on the photos and see the tiny details. This is my reference picture for the *Near Hamilton, N.Y* watercolour painting. To the right of my iPad is my rough sketch. I'm using Arches 300# hot press watercolour paper, and a Staedtler-Mars mechanical pencil, lead B. The sketch takes just a few minutes. For all artists, it's important to use the best materials that you can afford. Arches has always been expensive, but it takes the pigments so nicely. I savour every small piece that's left over to use for working on the colours before the brush hits the paper. Nothing is wasted in my studio.



2 ROUGH WASHES

The nice thing about the iPad is that you can zoom in on the subject matter to see the details. I quickly rough out the washes when I begin the paintings. I'm a bit apprehensive when I start. In just a few minutes I can establish my colours, and where I'm going to build up layers. Watercolours are made from ground pigments, mixed with gum Arabic. I generally use a mixture of Winsor & Newton, and Holbein pigments, which are both the gold standard of pigments.

3 STARTING THE DETAILS

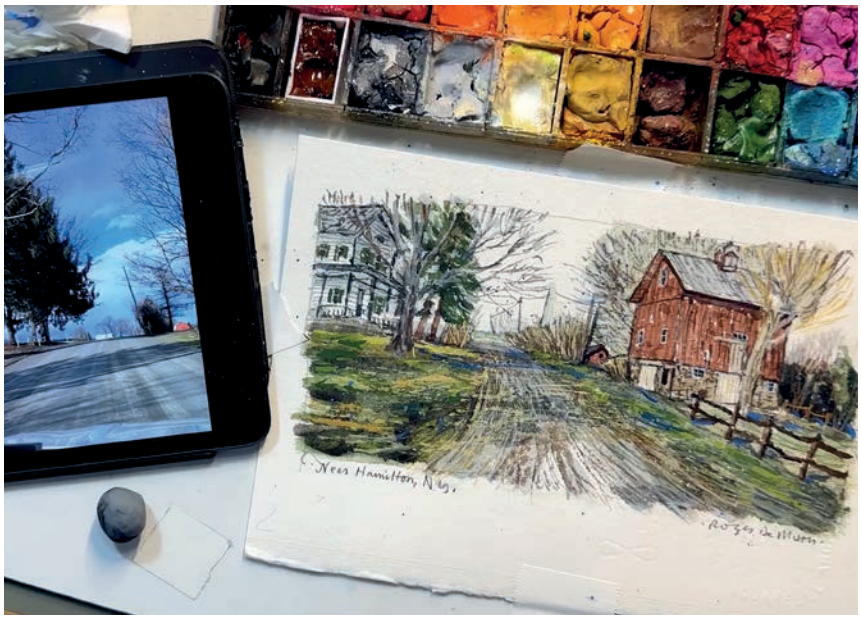
After the initial roughing in, I start to put some details into the painting with a Princeton long bristle liner brush. For larger areas, I have some old Winsor & Newton sable brushes and Percy Baker Brushes whilst I have recently discovered some W.A. Portman brushes which are very good, and all come to a fine point. In this image, I've started some outlining of shapes and details in the trees.

4 BOLD WASHES

Here, I'm using the side of the Winsor & Newton sable brush to further wash in larger areas. It's important to remember that watercolour when wet is quite a bit darker, then lightens up when dry. In any event, I've gone way too dark in this instance, and immediately thought I ruined the painting. I'll let it rest and have some coffee. It will take me awhile to bring the darkest part back to life with Gouache.

5 LINER BRUSH DETAILING

I did quite a bit of retouching with Gouache to lighten the dark shadows, but the painting is coming along nicely. I've lightened the colors, and now I'm giving the painting some spattering of pigment. I have my hand-built plexiglass Gouache palette ready to go and use an eye dropper filled with water to lightly wet the pigment. Gouache is a mixture of pigment, gum Arabic, and chalk. It works well with watercolours as it's more opaque. When spattering, a small brush produces small spots, so I tend to tap light on the brush with one finger. Large brushes produce spots which get in the way of the painting. Do some tests before painting.



6 LINER BRUSH THROUGHOUT

I'm nearing completion in this stage of the painting. I've lightened the shadows, reduced the width of the road and finished the outlining. Next, I darkened areas behind the barn on the right, punched up the contrast on the fence, and used Verditer blue spattering pigment in the shadow areas. I recently discovered Pastel pencils and finish my recent paintings with them. You can see the effect in this painting; I'll knock it down with a bit with gouache before I'm done to soften the look. I'll step away, have a sip of coffee and look at it to see if there's anything left to do. It's important for an artist to step back and look at what they've done. The pastel pencils are a good addition to the paintings and help to give them a subtle punch. Try them when you get a chance. Finally, I pencil in the title, location and my signature. □

ARGENTINA

Perfect match

RODNEY KINGSTON dons his wet weather gear and creates a busy football stadium scene in oil

MATCHDAY PAINTINGS OUTSIDE FOOTBALL STADIUMS have been a recurring theme in my work over the past year. The architecture of these vast structures, often set unexpectedly within tight urban spaces, provides rich compositional interest for an artist. Add in the movement of large crowds and the dominance of a club's colours, and there is no shortage of inspiration.

One aspect of *en plein air* painting I particularly enjoy is the opportunity to interact with people while I work. As a football fan, I've valued the conversations with supporters up and down the country. I don't shy away from telling them I'm a Spurs fan – even when painting the demonstration piece for this article!

I'll never forget Everton men's final game to be played at Goodison Park – their home ground for more than 130 years. It was May last year and I began painting at 7.30am on a bright spring morning. Hundreds of fans had gathered to bid farewell to the stadium and, as the day unfolded, the crowds grew in huge numbers. People climbed lampposts for a better vantage point of the team coach as it arrived for the game and flares filled the air with a cobalt blue haze as I was surrounded by thousands of Everton fans while painting. That experience cemented the direction of this body of work. Since then, I've painted numerous stadiums on matchdays, and made multiple visits to Brentford, Spurs, Liverpool, Fulham and Manchester City. Here, I share a step-by-step demonstration of an oil painting created outside Arsenal's Emirates Stadium.

rodneykingston.com ▸

RODNEY'S MATERIALS

Oil paints
Titanium White, Unbleached White, Cadmium Yellow, Yellow Ochre, Cadmium Red, Alizarin Crimson, Burnt Umber, Ultramarine Blue, Viridian

Brushes
Variety from Daler-Rowney and Rosemary & Co

Support
25X30cm MDF board with four coats of Gesso
Pochade painting box and tripod
D-ring hang metal pot with solvent
Kitchen roll and an old towel
Old bank card
Palette knife

1 THE BLANK CANVAS

Or in this case, a 3mm thick MDF board with four coats of acrylic gesso and a thin ground wash of Burnt Umber. I located a suitable place to paint with a view including interesting perspective, enough distance from the stadium to include the structure in the composition and – crucially – supporters arriving for the match. I was positioned on a public pavement where I wouldn't cause an obstruction.

2 DRAWING THE SCENE

Using Burnt Umber thinned with solvent, I drew the scene in paint using a size 2 round pointed brush. A good drawing provides a solid foundation to a painting so I took my time. It seemed to fall into place first try but on other occasions I have had to wipe away initial efforts and start again. That is why I 'draw' in paint because it is easy to correct using a clean brush, solvent and kitchen roll.

3 BLOCK IN THE DARKS

I blocked in large areas beginning with dark colours. The paint was thinned with solvent but thicker than the initial drawing. This stage helps confirm the drawing and provides an opportunity to correct anything that doesn't feel right.

4 PREPARING FOR THE WORST

Contending with the elements is an essential part of *en plein air* painting. My research the day before had informed me it would be cold and drizzly while at The Emirates Stadium, so I wore layers for warmth and packed an umbrella. I've tried various brolly attachments for the easel but have settled on just holding a medium size umbrella: it's big enough to protect the painting, but light enough to be held for a sustained period.

5 BLOCK IN LIGHTLY ▼

I completed the blocking in, reducing detail and painting over the entire drawing. The consistency of paint was just enough to cover the surface. I avoided going too thick with the paint because there are lots of details to add later and it's easier to paint them over a thin layer. A few areas were a bit thicker than intended so I scraped off some paint using an old bank card. ▶

6 TAKE AWAY SOME PAINT

At this stage the painting process became especially fun because it was time to pick out details. This silicon tipped tool literally highlights details by taking away paint to reveal the ground. I used it here to draw in the windows on the glass frontage of the stadium.

7 LIVING REFERENCES

This picture shows areas of the painting where I had developed the background with trees and steps. It also illustrates how the view is being populated by supporters. I had planned my time of arrival so that I would be at this stage of the painting approximately two hours before kick-off. It meant I could observe the fans and use them as reference for the work.

8 ADD PEOPLE AND STREET FURNITURE

I painted an impression of people arriving in the scene. I avoided detail when adding supporters which helped create a sense of movement. I also added street furniture such as lampposts and security barriers. I enjoyed the result of including these vertical elements to the composition which nicely countered the horizontal perspective.

9 SUPPORTERS' DETAILS

Further details were added. My view was constantly changing so I kept an eye on anything that might be interesting to include such as a supporter in the foreground who was wearing a number 8 shirt. One of the main appeals of this view was the lettering 'ARSENAL' which I added to the work at this stage using a rigger brush loaded with an off-white mix. By now my fingers were getting cold but I was satisfied I could pack up and use photo references in the studio to finish if required.

10 THE FINISHED PAINTING

The next day I reviewed the painting with fresh eyes back in my studio. I decided to add the lettering EMIRATES STADIUM but was careful to do this in a suggested way. The signage is in the background and my fear is the lettering will stand out if overly described. There are one or two other areas where I make minimal adjustments, before putting down the brushes and calling the painting finished. □

Let there be light

TOM SHEPHERD uses just three colours to capture the light and shadow of this vase of yellow flowers

As soon as I saw this subject I knew I wanted to paint it. The light becomes just as much the subject as anything, with those wonderful shapes of shadow crying out to be painted. I like to look at a subject in terms of simple tones: the light family and the shadow family. Not only does this give a clear way to analyse the subject, it keeps me firmly in the mindset of painting shapes rather than things, keeping me looser and more painterly.

The shadows become wonderful opportunities to link areas of similar tone with free-flowing washes, allowing colours to mingle and merge, resulting in beautiful variegation of colour and tone that brings depth and atmosphere into the shadows.

I love strong colour, but here chose a limited palette of just three colours. This encourages me to focus on tonal shapes, while pushing colour strength yet still maintaining harmony. In this case the strong yellow is complemented by muted greyish purples, with Indian Yellow acting as a secret weapon: strong or subtle, and able to swing vibrantly either warmer or cooler.

I use Baohong cold pressed paper, which has a lovely texture, stays wet in a very manageable way, and colours remain bold and crisp with minimal shift as they dry. It is also very forgiving and handles confident brushwork and larger washes beautifully.

schoolofwatercolour.com
Instagram: @ tomshepherdartist

TOM'S MATERIALS

Paints
Daniel Smith: Ultramarine Blue, Quinacridone Rose, Indian Yellow

Brushes
Pan Art: AquaMop, Synthetic Squirrel, sizes 8, 12, 16
Pointed round, size 12

Support
Baohong Masters Choice Paper, 300gsm, Cold Press, A3 Gummed Block 31×41cm

1 LAY DOWN WASHES

Starting with a watery wash of Indian Yellow, I quickly cover the top half of the dry page, leaving a few crisp whites. While still damp, I add a slightly thicker, creamy mix of Indian Yellow to create richer pockets of colour. Waiting a moment, I then introduce a light purplish grey, a milky mix of Quinacridone Red and Ultramarine Blue with a touch of yellow to mute it, letting the colours mingle while keeping some separation. ▶

2 INTENSIFY THE FLOWERS

I continue the greyish purple wash down the page, allowing natural variation as I go. Once everything reaches the damp stage, nearly dry but not quite, I drop in thicker, creamier pockets of Indian Yellow. This intensifies the yellow flowers without drifting into shadow tones, while also adding bursts of colour to echo the flowers elsewhere in the painting. I then leave this all to dry completely.

3 START ON THE LEAVES

Here I block in the lighter greens of the leaves. While still part of the light family, they are darker than the yellows, so easily painted over the top. This green mix of mostly Indian Yellow with a touch of blue is transparent and only a milky consistency, so the underlying dry yellow creates some lovely variegation of colour. Softening the occasional edge with a damp brush creates a mix of defined leaf shapes and more abstract areas.

4 NOW FOR THE SHADOWS

With the lighter washes dry, I begin with shadows as a creamy mix of yellow and red with a touch of blue to soften the colour. Squinting at my subject to avoid getting caught in details, I link these shadow areas with flowing washes, letting touches of the underlying yellow show through to suggest petals, and considering how shadows jigsaw into the light. While still damp, I add a thicker mix of the same colour to deepen the tones.

5 WORK ON THE BACKGROUND

Mixing a warm grey with all three colours, I create a flowing wash with enough pigment to produce a darkish midtone. I paint the negative shapes of the background to carve out the positive forms of the flowers and leaves, trapping the light at the same time. I work a little more carefully around the flowers, but keep the brush marks and washes big and bold as I move away from them.

6 DARK SHAPES

After dropping a thicker grey into the background while still damp, I mix a nice creamy blue and yellow to create the darker green leaf shadows. Sticking with the large mop brush to keep things loose, I paint simple dark green shadow shapes, leaving plenty of the lighter green showing. Linking some of the dark shapes here and there, I keep the marks simple and painterly, with a few extra flourishes and flicks to keep the energy and movement alive. ▶

7 FILL IN THE JUG

Starting with a flowing cream mix of red and blue, with a touch of yellow to tone it down, I block in the jug. The yellows and greens from above seep into it, which I love. I establish the overall tone first, allowing natural variegation. I aim for a simple yet accurate shape, trusting that, although it looks a little basic now, it will begin to make sense once the deeper shadow tones are added.

8 USE GREY TO ADD DEPTH

Continuing the wash into the cast shadow on the table, I use a large damp brush to soften edges and create a few bold marks to keep things lively. While the jug and shadow are still damp, I mix a thicker grey (using the same colours but with less water) and brush in darker patches here and there. Notice how this immediately creates a soft sense of depth in the shadows with minimal detail or fuss.

9 FINAL TOUCHES

While the bulk of the painting is working and done, it's amazing how much the final five percent can bring a watercolour to life. In this case it's a few extra dark green shapes to break up the yellow flowers, giving the illusion we are looking between them. I also add a few dry brush shadow accents on the jug, along with the odd flick of dry brush marks in the leaves and petals. Less is definitely more here: we don't need to resolve or define everything. Each area clearly sits either in light or shadow, with the flowers and leaves split into clear light and shadow shapes, and the shadow areas linked wherever possible, so they create strong underlying shapes of similar tone.

10 THE FINISHED PAINTING

So there we have it. The tonal shapes help provide the structure that holds the painting together, which takes us from watery and milky lighter washes, through into creamier shadows. Light becomes the subject, giving us simple tonal areas as opportunities to play with free-flowing washes and bold brushwork, always holding in mind the idea that we are painting shapes rather than things. □

Pad A3

Pad A4

Pad A5

Tom Shepherd on paper

I love colour and bold brushstrokes. Colours on Baohong Masters' Watercolour Paper come out so clean, clear and vibrant, with hardly any colour-shift from wet to dry. The paper handles tons of water and pigment, along a wide range of mark making techniques with absolute ease. Baohong Masters' Watercolour Paper is my favourite, and it is a joy to work with!

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Milford Art Group
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Email: deborahmoontree@gmail.com
Phone: 01425 627880
milfordartgroup.com

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Email: via website
essexart.club

Toynbee Art Club
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Email: r.wilson.123@btinternet.com
Phone: 020 7240 0475
toynbeeartclub.org.uk

EAST MIDLANDS

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Mickleover Community Centre, 8 Uttoxeter Road, Mickleover, Derby DE3 0DA
Email: via website
derbysketchingclub.co.uk

Hunloke Art Club
Walton Village Hall, Chesterfield, Derbyshire S42 7LT
Email: hunlokeartclub@outlook.com
Phone: 07984 887133
fieldbreaksart.co.uk/Hunloke-Art-Club

Leicester Sketch Club
c/o Art Room at Leicester High School for Girls, 454 London Road, Leicester LE2 2PP
Email: enquiries@leicestersketchclub.co.uk
leicestersketchclub.co.uk

Muskham Art Group
South Muskham Village Hall, near Newark, Nottinghamshire NG23 6EE
Email: via website
Phone: 01636 605875
muskhamartgroup.co.uk

WEST MIDLANDS

Association of Animal Artists
Granary Art Gallery, Weston Park, Shifnal, Shropshire TF11 8LE
Email: via website
associationofanimalartists.com

Hagley Art Club
Hagley Community Centre, Worcester Road, Hagley, Worcestershire DY9 0NW
Email: hagleyartclub583@gmail.com
hagleyartclub.co.uk

Walsall Society of Artists
St Martins Church, Sutton Road, Walsall, West Midlands WS5 3DQ
Email: via website
walsallsocietyofartists.co.uk

NORTH WEST

Ashton Art Group
Community & Childcare Centre, Hilton Street, Ashton-in-Makerfield, Wigan, Lancashire WN4 8PD
Email: via website
ashtonartgroup.co.uk

Grosvenor Art Society of Chester
Upton by Chester Golf Club, Coburg Road, Chester CH2 1EE
Email: via website
grosvenorarts.org.

Salford Art Club
The Crescent, Salford M5 4WU
Email: salfordartclub@outlook.com
Phone: 07925 044413
salfordartclub.com

WALES

Newport Art Group (Pembrokeshire)
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Email: via website
newportartgroup.co.uk

SOUTH WEST

Blandford Arts Society
Pimperne Village Hall, Newfield Road, Pimperne, near Blandford Forum, Dorset DT11 8UZ
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Phone: 07523 086881
blandfordartsociety.weebly.com

Cheltenham Art Club
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Email: members@cheltenhamartclub.co.uk

Exmouth Art Group
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exmouthartgroup.co.uk

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theartssociety.org/n-ireland

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glasgowartclub.co.uk

Milton of Campsie Art Club
Milton of Campsie Village Hall, School Lane, East Dunbartonshire, Scotland G66 8DD
Email: enquiry@mocartclub.uk
Phone: 01360 311944
mocartclub.uk

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Art and about

The UK is home to an eclectic bunch of artists, keen to show what they've been up to. We tell you what's on around the country this month

THE DARTMOUTH ARTIST – DEVON

In this workshop, Sarah Smith will guide you step-by-step through creating your own still life painting. Be inspired by the live studio set-up featuring flowers, crockery, and a carefully curated selection of interesting objects, designed to spark creativity.

The workshop is suitable for all abilities, and you'll receive one-to-one support throughout the session. If you've never painted before, there's no need to worry. It's a relaxed, welcoming space where you can try something new, build confidence, and learn a fresh set of skills at your own pace.

Whether you're a complete beginner or looking to reconnect with art, you'll be gently guided throughout the process and encouraged to enjoy the experience as much as the painting itself.

Still life acrylic painting workshop. Sunday 14 June, 1-4pm. £50. ***thedartmoorartist.co.uk/product/still-life-workshops-devon***

SOUTH WEST ART SPACE – SIDMOUTH

A new printmaking studio opens in Sidmouth this year, building on South West Art's long-standing reputation as one of the region's trusted specialist art suppliers. Founded by Lynsey and Graham Pickwell, the business has grown over two decades from a high street shop into a hub for materials, expertise and creative community. South West Art SPACE marks a natural next step. A fully equipped, non-toxic printmaking studio, it offers workshops, studio hire and private tuition just moments from the coast. Responding to renewed appetite for hands-on making, the space removes barriers to printmaking with safe processes and support from experienced artists. Visiting tutors and seasonal courses, including Summer School, position it as both local resource and creative retreat destination. *Sidmouth, south west England.* ***southwestartmaterials.co.uk***

WIMBLEDON ART FAIR – LONDON

Wimbledon Art Fair returns this May, offering a rare chance to step inside one of London's largest working studio complexes for four days of contemporary art direct from makers. Set in a converted Victorian factory, Wimbledon Art Studios opens over 180 studios to the public, allowing visitors to view and buy original work commission-free. The fair foregrounds process as much as product, with painters, ceramicists, sculptors, photographers and designers working on site. Alongside open studios, highlights include a launch night with live music, a mini-masterpiece sale, and family art trails designed to welcome younger audiences into the studios. *From 14 to 17 May 2026, Wimbledon Art Studios, London SW17 0BB.* ***wimbledonartfair.com***

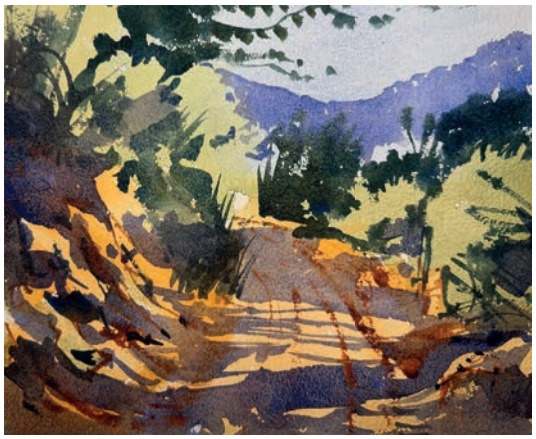
WOKINGHAM *EN PLEIN AIR* – WOKINGHAM

Wokingham's town centre becomes an open-air studio this June as R Young Art Gallery launches a major community project. Wokingham *En Plein Air* brings artists and audiences together for live painting across streets, squares and public spaces. Across 49 locations, 122 artists will work outdoors for 6.5 hours, capturing the town in real time. The event ends with a public exhibition in Market Place, alongside judging and awards, allowing visitors to view and purchase completed works. The emphasis is on visibility and participation, with creativity unfolding in public rather than behind gallery walls, and supports local engagement. *14 June 2026, Wokingham town centre.* ***enpleinairadventures.com***

ROSE STREET BY MELANIE PLAYER, WATERCOLOUR, 297X42CM

ASK THE EXPERT

All in the mind



Frank Walters has spent a lifetime in advertising before becoming a watercolour tutor during COVID. He believes psychology vital in painting and teaches his students the techniques attached to a success mindset.

1. Composition

Frank's main mantra is "Don't be a slave to what you see, be the master of what you want." Many students see a scene before them and believe they are duty-bound to recreate it as a camera might. Of course, focal points, vanishing lines, and the rule of thirds are all crucial, but the soul of the scene is about one's own interpretation.

2. The first light wash

Transparent watercolour is unlike any other medium; the white is already painted for you. Your ongoing task is to retain light whenever and wherever you can. Start with your cool blue sky, keep it fresh with lots of wet-in-wet, then move down to your warm Raw Sienna earth colours.

3. The mid-tones

Now, we move to the heart of the painting, where we start our mark-making. We draw with the brush, not with the pencil. Every brush stroke you make will be important, so much consideration is required; ultimately, this is where one's personal style is developed. Less is always better than more, and light retention continues.

4. Calligraphy

This is where we get the rigger brush out for some exciting dark bits of dry brush detail, keeping everything loose and almost half-painted. Some of the best work looks like the artist hasn't even tried!

5. The final dark shadow wash.

We finally arrive at the magic moment when the painting suddenly all comes together.

Frank teaches watercolour painting on Zoom every Wednesday at 2.30pm. He also has painting retreats in Andalusia, Tuscany and on the Côte d'Azur ***frankwatercolours.com*** ▸

DAVID HOCKNEY: SUNLEY WINDOW – MARGATE

Turner Contemporary marks its 15th anniversary with a major commission by David Hockney, transforming the Sunley Window into a vast seafront installation. Measuring seven by 10 metres, it runs until November 2026. The work depicts a Normandy sunrise from Hockney's 2020 seasonal series, reimagined as a floor-to-ceiling installation that links interior and exterior space. Rendered as an iPad painting, it reflects his ongoing exploration of digital technique, light and perception. Positioned on Margate's coastline, the work creates a dialogue with JMW Turner and becomes a luminous beacon after dark, extending the gallery experience beyond opening hours.

Until 1 November 2026, Turner Contemporary, Margate.
turnercontemporary.org

RAVENINGHAM SCULPTURE TRAIL – NORFOLK

The Raveningham Sculpture Trail returns for its 13th edition, bringing 60 artists into dialogue with landscape across gardens, meadows and woodland around a Tudor farmhouse in Norfolk. This year's theme, RITUAL, explores repetition in human experience, from personal habits to communal ceremonies and imagined futures. Artists respond through sculpture, installation, performance and interdisciplinary work, creating a shifting environment where art meets nature. A new Sculpture Trails Film Festival introduces animated works screened in an outdoor MicroKino space, extending the theme into moving image. Curated by Sarah Cannell, the trail emphasises accessibility and experimentation, encouraging visitors to explore at their own pace. Awards for Curator's Choice, Visitor's Choice and Best Animation close the exhibition.

From 15 July to 6 September 2026, Wed-Sun 10am-5pm, Raveningham Centre, South Norfolk.
raveninghamsculpturetrail.com

LONDON CRAFT WEEK – LONDON

London's annual celebration of making returns this May, bringing a city-wide programme championing craft forms. Spanning 150 venues, London Craft Week invites visitors into studios, galleries historic buildings to discover people, processes and materials behind ceramics, textiles, furniture, fashion. Highlights this year include collaborations with JW Anderson and Sotheby's, alongside the return of the Pimlico Road Series, a hub for interiors and design brands. Across the capital, workshops, demonstrations and exhibitions focus on skill and material knowledge, while an expanded City programme opens rarely seen spaces from livery halls to specialist ateliers. International showcases and museum partnerships broaden the scope, positioning craft as both a living tradition and contemporary force. *From 11 to 17 May 2026, London.* ***londoncraftweek.com***

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Each month, we feature products that will highlight and help your art practice

OCEAN INK

This is a pioneering seaweed-based ink available across Cass Art stores and online. The launch brings together Cass Art's long-standing heritage as a champion of artists and creative practice with OCEANIUM's material innovation, introducing an art material designed to support more conscious, responsible approaches to making.

OCEAN INK is fully biodegradable, non-toxic and microplastic-free seaweed-based ink. Designed for drawing, painting, screen printing and experimental mark-making, it offers artists an alternative to conventional inks that can contain persistent synthetic chemicals and microplastics, which may enter waterways during use and clean-up. OCEAN INK is available exclusively at Cass Art. ***cassart.co.uk***

SCHMINCKE: HORADAM WATERCOLOUR SET

Schmincke's second Retro Edition revives the spirit of the 1930s by bringing historical colours from its archive back to life, reinterpreted for today's artists. Beyond nostalgic design, the focus lies on carefully curated sets. A standout is the HORADAM watercolour set based on DIN 201, originally developed for architects, technical draughtsmen and cadastral surveyors to produce their technical drawings. These precisely balanced, classic shades now reveal their versatility in contemporary watercolour painting, bridging functional clarity with artistic freedom. The set combines heritage, quality and timeless colour aesthetics in a uniquely relevant way. ***schmincke.de/en***

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elevateartworks.com □

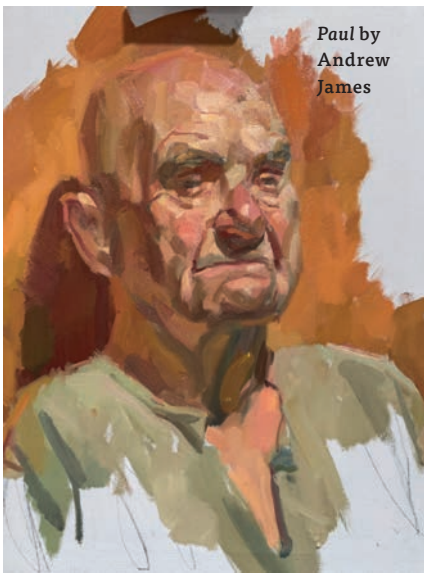
RAW UMBER studios

PORTRAIT PAINT OFF 2026

Face appeal

Leidy by Viktoria Riasnianka

Leidy by Christina Cruz



Paul by Andrew James

Leidy by Vryinda Pahuja

We're really pleased to be supporting this year's RAW UMBER STUDIOS Paint Off again. It's a live, free-to-enter portrait painting competition. Your move

Live paint offs are one of the most exciting, invigorating ways to challenge yourself and your peers. Last year, we proudly went into partnership with Raw Umber for their Portrait Paint Off competition. Our contribution was a stand-alone feature and a six-page feature on the winning artist, showcasing their process and stunning artwork.

2025's accolade went to Phoebe Stewart-Carter. "Competitions, such as Raw Umber Studio's Portrait Paint Off, have been crucial to getting my work seen, "she says. "Entering these competitions has enabled my work to be shown internationally and to appear in publications and online media, which has put me in contact with collectors and fellow painters from all over the world. I am still very much working on my business strategy as an artist, but I know how much these competitions have done to enable me in furthering my career. My advice to any artist would be to get involved with as many open opportunities as possible."

We're delighted to be involved in the Paint Off again. We tip our hats at Raw Umber's commitment to supporting artists and look forward to featuring this year's winner amongst these pages. Easels at the ready.

The Paint Off will be on 26 June 2026. You can find out more at ***rawumberstudios.com/paint-off*** *#rawumberpaintoff* □

Deadline for entries: 18 May 2026

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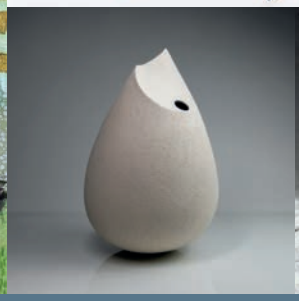
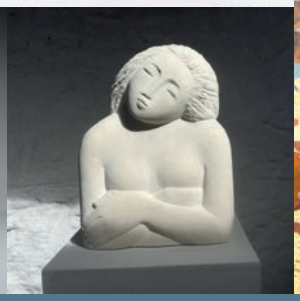

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PORTRAIT PAINTING
DOCUMENTING PEOPLE AND TECHNOLOGY IN THE DIGITAL AGE

WARM SUMMER SCENES
BY NAOMI TOMKYS OBE, A BRITISH ART PRIZE FINALIST

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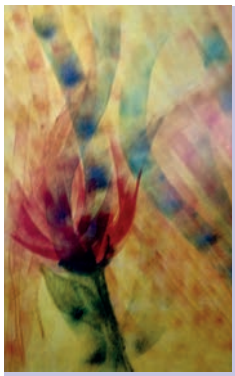

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Beneath the Surface, oil on wood, 30x30cm

Picture this

In every issue, we ask an artist to tell us about a piece of work that is definative of them. This month, we speak to acrylic artist **REBECCA DREARY**

This painting speaks directly to personal experiences of living with depression, both my own and that of my mother. Mental health struggles have long shaped the atmosphere of our home, often revealing themselves in subtle but persistent ways – through the buildup of everyday tasks left undone. Spaces like the sink, the fridge and the cupboards become indicators of something much deeper.

The kitchen sink became a powerful symbol for me, which is why I have painted an entire series of sinks. It is a site of constant accumulation – no matter how often it is cleared, more dishes inevitably gather. I used to find this deeply distressing, yet at the same time felt an equally strong inability to confront the problem. That tension between awareness and paralysis is something I wanted to capture.

Through painting these uncomfortable scenes, I have begun to reframe how I see them. What once felt like failure or neglect has become an opportunity to explore the human condition with greater empathy. The title, *Beneath the Surface*, reflects this duality. The obscured bowl beneath the water acts as a metaphor for the aspects of ourselves that we keep hidden from view – both from others, and at times ourselves. Much like the submerged objects in the sink, these struggles exist just out of sight, shaping our everyday lives whist often going unspoken.

For those who resonate with the themes of mental health, I hope that my work offers a sense of recognition and reassurance.

rebeccadearystudio.myshopify.com □

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